HT NEW DELHI VOL. 20 NO. 270

Wednesday, November 11, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

What fiscal support means for India's energy storage

BY RITURAJ BARUAH

The Union cabinet last week approved ₹14,500 crore in viability gap funding (VGF) to build 92GWh of grid-scale energy storage. The scheme will help ensure a more reliable power supply and stabilize the country's electricity grid. *Mint* explains the move.

ISTOCKPHOTO

1 What does the VGF scheme entail?

Financial support of ₹14,500 crore will be provided between FY27 and FY31, under the scheme. It aims to support 30GWh of battery energy storage systems (BESS), 60GWh of pumped storage projects (PSP) and 2GWh of emerging storage tech. These projects, which are estimated to require an investment of ₹97,600 crore, will be allocated via a tariff-based competitive bidding process. Both public- and private-sector electricity distribution firms will be eligible for fiscal support. The government has mandated that BESS developers source at least 40% of their components from Indian manufacturers.

2 Why is energy storage important for India?

Energy storage systems are key to storing excess renewable energy (RE) for use when green power sources such as solar and wind are unavailable. As RE generation capacity has risen, there have been instances when solar power generation exceeds demand. Without storage, this surplus power is wasted. Discoms and developers resort to distress sales of power on exchanges at peak solar hours (11am–3pm), resulting in financial losses. Since solar and wind are intermittent sources of power, sudden surges or drops in supply can also destabilize the grid. Energy storage can help prevent such disruptions.

ISTOCKPHOTO

3 What is the difference between BESS and PSP?

BESS relies on batteries to store excess electricity which it transmits to the grid when demand rises. PSPs, in turn, use surplus power to pump water back into reservoirs and reuse it to generate power in times of demand. Also, while BESS can quickly help steady the grid and meet peak demand, PSPs are better to store power generation potential for longer.

4 Can grid-level energy storage help users?

Energy storage systems integrated with the power grid will help ensure a more reliable supply of good-quality electricity. They are designed to support round-the-clock availability of power, potentially reducing power cuts and improving supply reliability. Further, BESS can store relatively inexpensive renewable electricity generated during solar or windy hours and supply it when these sources are unavailable. Over time, this may lead to savings by the discoms and translate into lower electricity bills for consumers.

5 Are India's storage needs factored in?

As renewable energy capacity expands, the need for energy storage is expected to rise. India will require 411GWh (73.93GW) of grid-scale storage capacity by 2031-32, the government says. The Central Electricity Authority (CEA) projects that, of the 73.93GW storage capacity required by 2031-32, 26.69GW will come from PSP and 47.24GW from BESS. CEA's long-term plan projects a need for 888GWh of energy storage by 2035-36, comprising 80GW battery storage and 94GW of pumped hydro storage capacity.

QUICK EDIT

L'affaire Huang

Nothing seems to be going right for the artificial intelligence (AI) trade anymore. After Anthropic's prospectus faced unusually tough questions, and the 'Blue Wave' in the US mid-terms sparked concerns about the data centre boom, a leading chipmaker is now embroiled in an unusual controversy. Nvidia's chief Jensen Huang has admitted that he had an affair with Alice Huang, an alleged Chinese spy. While the Chinese government has refuted spying charges, Nvidia has initiated an inquiry on these charges. Nvidia's stock fell 4% on Monday, erasing nearly $200 billion in market valuation.

Huang's fate may have consequences for the wider AI industry. As a key advisor of US President Donald Trump, Huang helped shape the Trump administration's hands-off policy towards AI firms. With Huang likely to take a backseat in policy affairs, voices favouring greater regulation of AI companies may gain strength.

The diminishing enthusiasm for the AI trade has already lifted sentiments for Indian stocks over the past few days, with several brokerages revising their Nifty 50 targets upward. The Huang affair may provide a further fillip.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

I stand beside every one of these operations. I was proud to execute them, and I would do it again tomorrow.

PETE HEGSETH
US DEFENSE SECRETARY

He made this comment at a news conference, referring to the moves to impeach him over abuse of power in the Iran war

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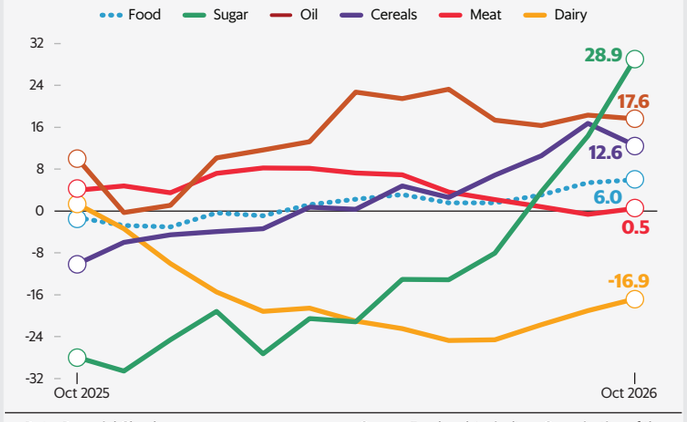
mint | DATA BITES

HOW WERE GLOBAL FOOD PRICES IN OCTOBER 2026?

The FAO Food Price Index rose 6% year-on-year to 115.4 in October, led by a 29% surge in sugar prices, partly due to concerns over India's output after deficient, uneven monsoon rainfall.

Year-on-year change in food commodity price index, in % (2014-16=100)



Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Deepak Mishra

Source: Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, Mint calculations

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PLAIN FACTS

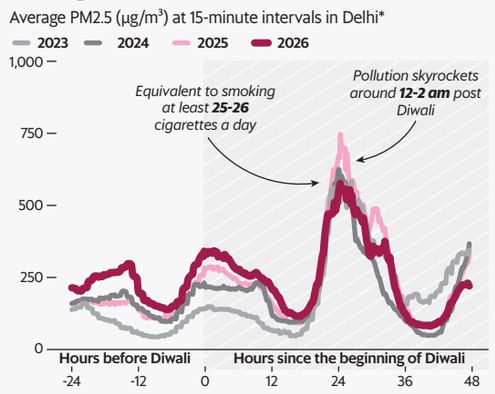
THE STORY OF DIRTY AIR AFTER DIWALI

BY ANJISHNU DAS, PRAGYA SRIVASTAVA & RUPANJAL CHAUHAN

Like clockwork, Delhi and surrounding regions wake up to a blanket of grey smog a day after Diwali. Visibility drops; the metallic smell of fine particles hangs in the air. Pollution readings are so high that monitoring stations go blank for hours, raising questions about the robustness of the data even as they underscore Diwali's brutal impact on air quality. While Delhi makes the headlines, more than 200 cities also recorded a sharp deterioration in air quality after Diwali, particularly across northern and central India. But the festival is only part of the problem. Stubble burning had already added to pollution in the days leading up to Diwali. Now, winter's cold air will trap pollutants close to the ground, making clean air a distant dream until at least February.

Every year, air pollution numbers go through the roof after Diwali celebrations

Average PM2.5 (μg/m³) at 15-minute intervals in Delhi*



*Average of available data from 59 air quality monitoring stations in Delhi.

Source: Central Pollution Control Board, Mint calculations | mint

CHOKED CITY

DIWALI CELEBRATIONS trigger a severe environmental crisis every year, with air pollution levels surging five to seven times within hours. A *Mint* analysis of PM2.5—a measure of microscopic, toxic air particles that can penetrate deep into your lungs—at 15-minute intervals by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) across 59 air pollution stations in Delhi shows that the levels begin rising around 5pm on Diwali day and skyrocket between midnight and 2am, reaching 500-700 micrograms per cubic metre after the festivities.

For perspective, these levels are equivalent to smoking at least 25-26 cigarettes in a single day. Data from 2023 to 2026 shows that the post-Diwali surge is a recurring annual phenomenon and not an anomaly. Pollution reached dangerously high levels in 2025 and 2026, despite the Supreme Court allowing only certified green crackers between 6am and 7am and 8pm and 10pm around Diwali. The recurring spike exposes the gaps in pollution control.

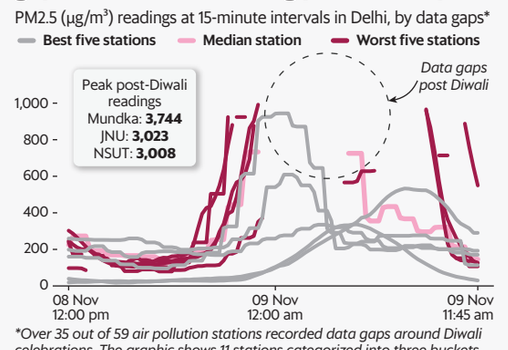
DATA DARKNESS

WHILE DIWALI lights up the entire country, the spike in air pollution levels makes data go dark. A *Mint* analysis of 15-minute interval PM2.5 readings over 24 hours, from noon on 8 November to noon on 9 November, found that only 4,439 of 5,664 data points were available, leaving 22% missing, up from 14% three years ago. The missing readings, spread across at least 35 stations, were concentrated around midnight on 9 November, when pollution spiked. This often happens when sensors reach their measurement limit of 1,000 micrograms per cubic metre or filter tapes clogged by particulate matter trigger automatic safety shut-offs.

Separate PM2.5 data from the Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) showed readings peaking at 3,744 micrograms per cubic metre at Mundka around 2am on 9 November. Eleven of the 30 stations recorded readings above 2,000 micrograms per cubic metre, raising questions over data robustness and whether it understates pollution during peak hours.

Data goes dark in several stations, with gaps of 5-12 hours during post-Diwali peak

PM2.5 (μg/m³) readings at 15-minute intervals in Delhi, by data gaps*

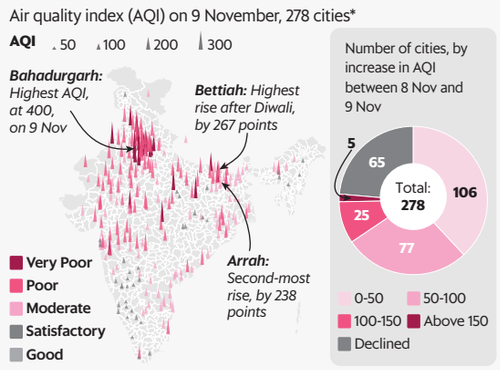


*Over 35 out of 59 air pollution stations recorded data gaps around Diwali celebrations. The graphic shows 11 stations categorized into three buckets based on the PM2.5 data points available out of 96 prints at 15-minute intervals between 12 pm on 8 November and 12 pm on 9 November. The worst five recorded 46-52 data points only, the median 76, and the best five all 96.

Source: Central Pollution Control Board, Mint analysis | mint

A day after Diwali, AQI was 'poor' or 'very poor' in as many as 125 cities

Air quality index (AQI) on 9 November, 278 cities*



*Shows data for cities for which data was available for both 8 and 9 November and captures 24-hour average between 4 pm of both days.

Source: Central Pollution Control Board, Mint calculations | mint

NATIONAL AFTER-EFFECTS

DELHI'S AIR pollution levels are notoriously high, but several other cities also witnessed a sharp post-Diwali deterioration in air quality.

On Diwali, 191 cities recorded moderate or worse air quality index (AQI) levels. A day after the celebrations, the number had risen to 246. In fact, the worst 24-hour reading on 9 November was not in Delhi but in Bahadurgarh in Haryana, where the AQI reached 400, placing it in the severe category. Of the 278 cities for which the AQI data was available for both 8 and 9 November, 213 recorded an increase in AQI levels.

Out of these, 30 cities witnessed increases of more than 100 points in AQI. Some cities in Bihar stood out: Bettiah and Arrah recorded the highest post-Diwali increases—in excess of 200 points on the index—pushing their air quality from good/satisfactory levels, respectively, on Diwali, into the 'poor' zone the next day. As many as 51 cities slipped from good/satisfactory levels to moderate/poor levels.

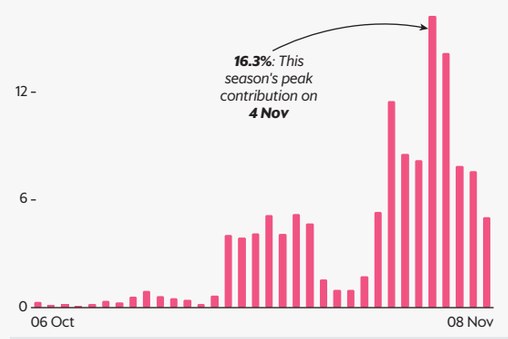
BURNING BUILD-UP

THE BRUTAL impact of Diwali celebrations is undeniable, but it would be wrong to blame a few days of firecrackers for months of poor air quality, particularly in northern India. Delhi's air quality was already in the "very poor" category ahead of Diwali, as colder air trapped pollutants near the ground and stubble burning added to the pollution load. Data from the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology shows that the contribution of stubble burning to Delhi's PM2.5 levels began rising from 20 October, reaching 16.3% on 4 November before easing to 5% on 8 November.

This pre-Diwali build-up adds to the pollution burden every year. A study published by *Atmospheric Chemistry and Physics* in July 2026 said that India's open burning emissions contributed 8% to annual PM2.5 levels across India in 2022. While these levels may be smaller than 18% from industry and 15-16% from residential and power generation, the timing of stubble burning in October-November makes matters worse.

Stubble burning contributed significantly to Delhi's air pollution leading up to Diwali

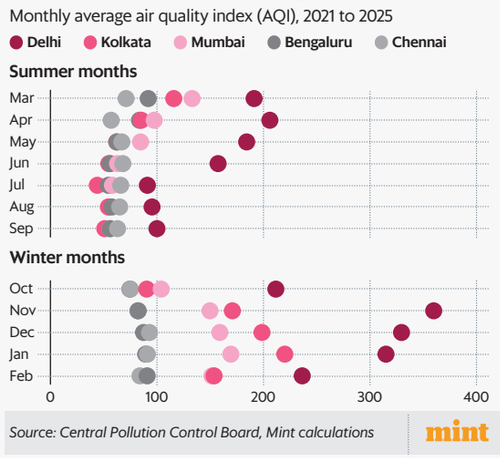
Daily mean contribution from stubble burning to PM2.5 concentrations in Delhi (in %)



Source: Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology | mint

Air quality begins worsening in October and stays elevated throughout the winter

Monthly average air quality index (AQI), 2021 to 2025



Source: Central Pollution Control Board, Mint calculations | mint

WINTER IS COMING

THE WORSENING of air quality begins in October and persists through February. This pattern extends beyond Delhi and northern India, with other major cities mirroring it, albeit at much lower pollution levels. From 2021 to 2025, Delhi, Mumbai, Chennai and Bengaluru each recorded higher average AQI levels in the 10 days after Diwali than in the 10 days before it.

The post-Diwali spike does not fully dissipate. Air pollution remains elevated across these cities from October to February, with Delhi recording its highest monthly average AQI every November. Chennai sees its worst air quality in December, while Kolkata and Mumbai's worst is in January. Diwali and stubble burning add to the pollution as winter sets in and colder air traps pollutants closer to the ground. But the fact that Delhi records satisfactory air quality for just two months a year, both during the monsoon, calls for deeper investigation and more concrete action.

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The spy scandal that lays bare Nvidia's governance void ▶P12

Blackstone picks up 16% in IIFL Fin for ₹5,000 crore ▶P7

SENSEX **81,106.65** ↔ **0.00** NIFTY **25,044.65** ↔ **0.00** DOLLAR **₹93.94** ↔ **₹0.00** EURO **₹105.14** ↔ **₹0.00** OIL **$90.5** ↓ **$2.37** POUND **₹126.11** ↓ **₹0.07**

Depleting reservoirs cast a cloud over crops, power

Falling rabi sowing signals smaller harvest; hydropower production may decline

Vijay C. Roy & Rituraj Baruah
NEW DELHI

Scanty rains of the southwest monsoon have left India's key reservoirs severely depleted, threatening irrigation, agricultural output and hydropower generation. Reservoirs that were over 90% full last year are now not even two-thirds full, official data showed, following one of the driest monsoon seasons in decades.

Water levels at India's 178 reservoirs supplying irrigation canals, hydropower units and municipal drinking water are down 27% from a year ago to 121.9 billion cubic metres (bcm), data from the Central Water Commission showed. The dry spell is already rippling through the rural economy, where six states have declared drought, rabi crop sowing has dropped, and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has warned of mounting risks to food inflation.

Apart from the central region where water levels were marginally above last year's, storage was lower in all other regions.

The water scarcity was worst in the southern region, where reservoirs are only 42.6% full (against last year's 89.97%), compared with north having 56.62% (86.32%), west 76.17% (96.10%), east 75.74% (81.66%) and central 84.23% (92.01%). While the southwest monsoon that brings most of India's rains has concluded, the northeast monsoon remains active in the southern peninsula, raising hopes of further rains in catchment areas.

Not surprisingly, sowing has slipped. Crops were sown across 11.7 million hectares till 6 November, 2.43 million hectares below last year's 14.1 million at this time. To be sure, rabi sowing is still on, and typically continues till the end of December. India's average rabi acreage in the FY21 to FY25 period was 70.1 million hectares.

Less water for irrigation may impact sowing and harvest, experts pointed out.

"Low reservoir levels, particularly in the western and southern regions, could affect rabi crop cultivation, as farmers in these areas depend heavily on reservoir water for irrigation. Crops such as wheat, paddy, pulses and oilseeds could face irrigation constraints if water availability remains limited during critical growth stages," said Sudhir Panwar, a farm policy expert and former member of Uttar Pradesh Planning Commission.

Wheat acreage has slipped 12% to 1.97 million hectares, rice 3.1% to 673,000 hectares, and pulses 14.4% to 3.2 million hectares, agriculture ministry data showed.

However, some experts said the impact will be limited in the northwestern region.

"The impact of lower reservoir levels on rabi crops is seen negligible in northwestern India as the region is well-irrigated. Moreover, wheat, a major rabi crop in the region, needs relatively less water and all the growing areas are irrigated. Impact is likely to be concentrated in areas where farmers depend heavily on reservoir water for irrigation," said A.K. Singh, former director, Indian Agricultural Research Institute(ICAR).

The World Meteorological Organization (WMO) warned in September that the 2026 El Niño

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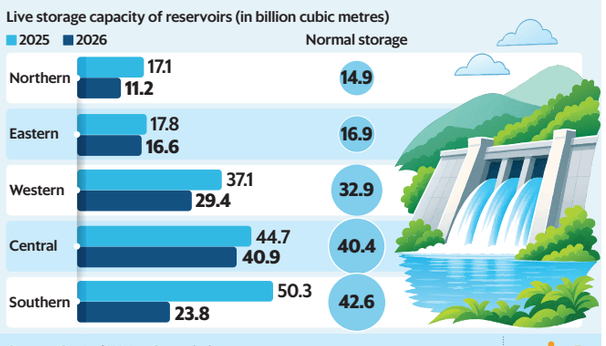
DRY DAYS

Water levels at 178 reservoirs are down 27% from a year ago. The key reason is the weak monsoon, with rainfall at 87% of long-term average



Source: Central Water Commission

mint

RAIN DROP

RABI acreage this year is already below last year's levels

SIX states declared drought, rabi crop sowing has dropped

THE water scarcity is worst in the southern region

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

JSW to skip latest airport bids on viability concerns

Dipali Banka
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Billionaire Sajjan Jindal-led JSW Group has ruled out bidding in the government's latest airport privatization round, at least for now. The airport sector was seen as an area of interest for the conglomerate as part of its diversification push beyond steel.

JSW's decision came after an internal review concluded that airports are "a quasi-real estate play". It, however, remains open to a rethink if bigger city airports, such as Kolkata and Chennai, are opened up.

"We set up a small team to study the airport business. We evaluated the pros and cons, the investment required, and the returns. We realized it is a kind of real estate investment. We felt it doesn't fit into any of our existing businesses," Parth Jindal, the managing director of JSW Cements and JSW Paints and son of Sajjan Jindal, told *Mint*.

The team, that was formed under JSW Infrastructure and included Ashwin Noronha, former chief operating officer of Mumbai International Airport Ltd, concluded that the small assets are not profitable.

Parth Jindal, MD of JSW Cements and JSW Paints.

In the latest privatization round, 11 airports of the Airports Authority of India (AAI) will be offered to private operators under the public-private partnership model in five bundles: Amritsar-Kangra, Varanasi-Gaya-Kushinagar, Bhubaneswar-Hubballi, Raipur-Aurangabad and Tiruchirappalli-Tirupati. Bidding is likely to start next month, and the government expects to get at least ₹8,600 crore from this round, *Mint* reported on 25 August.

Jindal said the smaller airports could make business sense for existing operators looking to expand portfolios. "The major airports are taken. The 11 airports that are coming up (for auction) are smaller in

TURN TO PAGE 6

DON'T MISS

AFP

Brent near $90 offers relief on fiscal, inflation fronts

The Indian economy and OMCs may get some relief as oil prices hover near four-month lows on Tuesday. At around 6:30pm, Brent crude's January contract on the ICE was trading at $90.22 a barrel, down 2.54% from its previous close. >P2

Manufacturers seek lower duties on inputs as costs hurt

Manufacturers are seeking lower import duties on raw materials and intermediate goods in the budget for 2027-28, arguing that high input costs are hurting domestic production and making Indian goods less competitive. >P2

Oil, rural stress cloud outlook for consumer goods makers

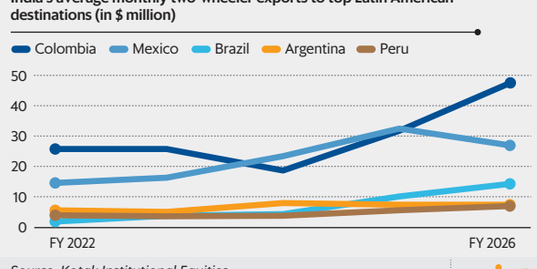
India's top consumer goods companies are heading into a challenging second half of the fiscal year, with rising input costs, pressure on margins and uneven demand threatening to erode the gains from volume growth in the September quarter. >P4

India flags rich countries' climate finance obligations

India has stepped up pressure on developed nations to honour their climate finance commitments, saying poorer countries can't be expected to shoulder the rising costs of fighting climate change while meeting their own development needs. >P11

LatAm focus

Colombia has emerged as the top destination for Indian two-wheelers, while demand is growing in Brazil and Mexico.



Source: Kotak Institutional Equities

mint

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Two-wheeler cos take the fast lane to Latin America

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

India's two-wheeler makers are sharpening their focus on Latin America as the region finds favour over Africa, traditionally their biggest export market. Colombia has emerged as the top destination for Indian motorcycles and scooters, while growing demand in Brazil and Mexico is nudging companies to boost manufacturing and offerings.

This is the fourth consecutive year that a Latin American nation has topped India's two-wheeler export destinations.

The shift is clear in average monthly export values in FY22 and FY26, data compiled by Kotak Institutional Equities shows. Exports to Colombia rose 87% to $48.2 million while the shipments to Mexico were up 83% to $26.7 million. Brazil saw a whopping 706% rise to $14.5 million. On the other hand, exports to Nigeria slid 58% to $15.6 million, while those to Uganda fell 24% to $6.1 million.

Top players Hero MotoCorp, Bajaj Auto, TVS Motor Co and Royal Enfield are raising investments with new factories, broader portfolios and deeper presence in Brazil, Mexico, and Colombia. The region is emerging as a second growth engine for the companies as the focus on electric mobility disrupts traditional markets in Africa.

Two main reasons are driving this move. In Latin America, motorcycles are increasingly being used as income-generating assets for delivery, courier and mototaxis, creating demand for commercial and utility-oriented models.

Meanwhile, in Africa, which has long been the main market for Indian two-wheelers, an early wave of electric bikes led by firms like Spiro could leave petrol-bike makers behind.

Bajaj, in its latest earnings call, indicated plans to enter new product segments in Latin America, while KTM has opened a dedicated 20,000-unit plant in Manaus, Brazil, alongside Bajaj Auto's existing facility. Hero has marked Brazil and Mexico as key growth markets, while TVS has attributed its recent export performance partly to stronger demand in Latin America.

"We are setting up a manufacturing facility in Brazil. And we also have a good portfolio of flex-fuel vehicles, which is what is needed for that mar-

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Win deal, get commission: how mid-size IT is luring sales staff

Jas Bardia
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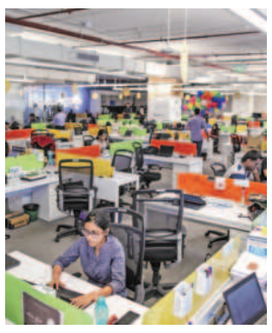
BENGALURU

Hexaware Technologies wants its salespeople to get "really, really rich". The information technology (IT) services company has replaced target-based sales incentives with commissions linked directly to the revenue employees bring in, betting that bigger rewards will translate into more business.



Firms are changing how they motivate sales teams. BLOOMBERG

Hexaware is not alone in rethinking how it wins contracts. As artificial intelligence (AI) reshapes client demand and competition intensifies, mid-sized IT services firms are changing how they motivate sales teams and reach customers. LTM Ltd is offering separate incentives for AI-native deals, while Coforge Ltd is turning to external deal advisors to access opportunities.

For IT services firms with $1-5 billion in annual revenue, the challenge is to find new sources of growth as AI changes technology spending, while competing against larger rivals for the business that remains.

Hexaware has shifted its sales team from a quota-based to a commission-based model, removing several performance thresholds that previously determined payouts.

"If you recall, on our AI day, Shantanu presented that very recently, we transitioned for our hunting team from a quota-based plan to a commission-based plan. And that's something that we expect is going to work out well," said Vikash Kumar Jain, chief financial officer of Hexaware at its earnings call on 29 October. The change was first outlined at the firm's AI Day on 21 August by president Shantanu Baruah.

"We believe we have the best hunting incentive plan in the area that we operate in," Baruah had said. "Just to give you a quick colour to that, our incentive plan has gone from many gate-based criteria of TCV (total contract value), ACVs (annual contract value) and all, to completely commission-based. Even if you're making a dollar for the company, you actually get a commission on that," said Baruah.

The commissions are separate from employees' variable pay, with additional payouts for selling certain solutions.

"Obviously, there are more

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Foreign regulators' data asks put cos in a legal bind

Krishna Yadav
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NEW DELHI

Indian companies are facing a growing number of requests for data from foreign regulators, putting them in a tricky position over what they can legally share. From customer records and transaction logs to internal chats and lab data, their demands are prompting businesses to bring in lawyers much earlier, rather than risk breaching laws.

Firms are seeking legal advice at a much earlier stage. ISTOCKPHOTO

Law firms say such work has picked up sharply in 2026, as companies prepare for the cross-border provisions of India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) law that takes effect in May. The requests are coming in from securities, financial, drug and law-enforcement agencies in the US, UK, EU and Singapore.

"We've seen a very clear uptick this year," said Vinay Butani, partner at Economic Laws Practice. "Those queries were quite occasional in the past, and are now quite regular, predominantly coming from global capability centres, the IT and outsourcing companies and the Indian arms of regulated foreign groups."

Nikhil Varshney, partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, said the rise is also linked to greater coordination among global law enforcement agencies and growing use of digitized, cloud-based corporate data in foreign investigations.

Companies now seek legal advice at a much earlier stage, Ambuj Sonal, partner at Dentons Link Legal, said. Organizations that once viewed such requests as routine compliance are now more conscious of Indian data protection, confidentiality, and sectoral mandates before sharing information with overseas authorities.

Sonal gave an example from the advisory in which an Indian IT services provider supporting an overseas financial institution got a foreign regulator's request for customer records and transaction logs. The company would need to assess its obligations under DPDP norms and other rules before sharing the data.

Whether or not companies are bound to respond to such requests depends on the nature of the ask and the law governing it. In legally binding requests, their failure to comply could have consequences

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Democrats are investigating the biggest American companies

Louise Radnofsky, Emily Glazer, C. Ryan Barber & Lindsay Ellis
WASHINGTON

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

For months, companies have been quietly preparing for the possibility that Democrats would win control of Congress and launch a wave of investigations. Now they are in a full sprint.

After dominating Tuesday's election, Democrats have spared no time throwing themselves into investigations of American corporations, dispatching letters telling companies they are targets and setting their deadline to produce records for Jan. 4, the first full day of the new Congress. Some of America's largest businesses—from Amazon to Apple, Live Nation to Walmart—are among the first to feel the heat.

Exit polls showed that anger about affordability and corruption were key motivations for voters in handing Democrats back both chambers of the legislature, prompting the party to be aggressive in pursuing big companies.

"Usually investigations are an outgrowth of an election; this time it was the point," said Simpson Thacher partner Rafi Prober, co-head of the firm's congressional-investigations practice.

Democratic Sen. Richard Blumenthal is set to chair the Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations. REUTERS

Lawyers say that companies are acting with fresh urgency. One lawyer recalled receiving a signed retainer from a client on Wednesday, after weeks of waiting for a response. Conflict-of-interest rules limit the clients that firms can take on, meaning that businesses that didn't already lock in experienced congressional-investigations lawyers are racing to catch up.

Some businesses started preparing months ago, hiring law firms such as Akin Gump, Arnold & Porter, Crowell & Moring and Quinn Emanuel. They have already been mapping out likely topics of scrutiny, collecting documents, interviewing employees and even running "wargame" simulations to start auditing and cataloging their exposure, according to lawyers and executives involved in the preparations.

Democrats have established a long list of interest areas, with corporate ties to President Trump and his legacy projects at the top of their list.

Two days after the election, Democratic Sen. Richard Blumenthal fired off dozens of letters, putting companies on notice that he planned to turn up the pressure.

Blumenthal, who is set to chair the Senate Permanent Subcommittee on Investigations, contacted household names such as Amazon, Apple, BlackRock, Booz Allen, Coinbase, Alphabet's Google, Microsoft, Salesforce, ServiceNow and Union Pacific, among others, as known donors to Trump's White House ballroom project.

He sent additional letters to cryptocurrency firms about their Trump family ties. And he

TURN TO PAGE 6

India seeks to cut oil imports and emissions. BLOOMBERG

Govt makes electric vehicles default for staff cars

Manas Pimpalkhare & Dhirendra Kumar

NEW DELHI

The finance ministry has made electric vehicles (EVs) the default choice for government staff cars, signalling a shift away from petrol and diesel vehicles in official fleets as India seeks to cut oil imports and vehicle emissions.

In a notification on Tuesday, the department of expenditure said ministries and departments should ordinarily procure EVs when replacing or retiring their existing internal combustion engine (ICE) staff cars. Departments seeking to buy an ICE vehicle instead will have to justify the decision through a detailed proposal to the expenditure department. A senior government official confirmed the development to *Mint*. The move is aimed at promoting electric mobility, reducing dependence on fossil fuels and taking into account prevailing vehicle prices and lifecycle costs, said the notification, seen by *Mint*. The government has also set a procurement ceiling of ₹20 lakh for EVs, higher than the ₹10 lakh limit for ICE and hybrid vehicles.

The decision comes as India seeks to become a net-zero carbon emitter by 2070. Transport accounts for 12% of the country's carbon emissions, according to the International Energy Agency. The shift to EVs could also help reduce India's dependence on imported oil, with the country meeting about 90% of its oil requirements through imports. It may also help curb vehicular pollution.

"Making EVs the default for government staff cars is a welcome step. Zero-emission vehicles cut tailpipe pollution, keep India's auto industry competitive as global markets electrify, and reduce our reliance on imported oil," said Amit Bhatt, India managing director of the International Council on Clean Transportation, a global think tank.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Indian manufacturers want lower duties on raw materials

Manufacturers are seeking these cuts in Budget 2027 as input costs are hurting production

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Industry associations have flagged high and uneven duties on inputs as a cost burden for downstream producers, particularly for MSMEs. BLOOMBERG

Manufacturers are seeking lower import duties on raw materials and intermediate goods in the budget for 2027-28, arguing that high input costs are hurting domestic production and making Indian goods less competitive, three people familiar with the discussions said.

From aluminium and textiles to chemicals and export-oriented manufacturing, industry associations have flagged high and uneven duties on inputs as a cost burden for downstream producers, particularly micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). In some cases, they have argued, imported finished products enjoy lower tariff rates than the raw materials used by domestic manufacturers.

The demands come as the finance ministry begins preparations for the next budget, which is scheduled to be presented on 1 February 2027. Industry bodies are meeting officials in the ministry and submitting their representations ahead of the exercise.

1 Feb '27
Day India's budget for 2027-28 is to be presented

According to a schedule issued by the Department of Economic Affairs on 23 September, pre-budget meetings with ministries and departments began on 12 October and are scheduled to conclude on 13 November.

The government has already provided temporary relief to some sectors. It exempted cotton imports from customs duties from 1 June 2026. The exemption, initially scheduled to end on 31 October, was extended until 31 December to improve raw-material availability for the textile industry.

In a joint pre-budget representation to finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, the Aluminium Extrusion Manufacturers Association of India (ALEMAI) and other industry bodies have sought a reduction in basic customs duty (BCD) on primary aluminium under tariff heading 7601 from 7.5% to zero. They argue that the existing tariff structure puts downstream manufacturers, particularly MSMEs that use aluminium as a key raw material, at a cost disadvantage.

Jitendra Chopra, president of ALEMAI, which represents more than 200 aluminium extrusion manufacturers across India, said the high cost of procuring raw materials had contributed to the closure of around 20 factories over the past three years, resulting in the loss of nearly 50,000 jobs.

"India has an installed aluminium extrusion capacity of 3 million tonnes, but the industry is currently operating at just 40% of capacity. Reducing customs duties on primary aluminium and aluminium scrap would lower input costs, improve capacity utilisation and help revive closed factories, creating employment opportunities," Chopra said.

He said the proposed duty rationalisation could generate an additional ₹4,400 crore in domestic taxable value addition and ₹792 crore in goods and services tax (GST) revenue at an illustrative rate of 18%. He said this would be equivalent to the customs revenue currently collected on primary aluminium imports.

The industry body PHDCCI has called for reducing the BCD on graphite electrodes from 7.5% to zero, citing their essential role in electric arc furnace steelmaking and the absence of a viable substitute for this application.

13 Nov
Last day of pre-budget meet with ministries, depts

"A rationalized customs duty framework for inputs such as molybdenum, ferro-alloys, graphite electrodes and steel scrap, while supporting domestic recycling and resource efficiency, can improve cost competitiveness, strengthen downstream industries and facilitate the transition towards more efficient steel production," said Anil Gupta, president, PHDCCI, during a pre-budget meeting.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Brent crude near $90 may give relief to economy, OMCs

Rituraj Baruah & Banikinkar Pattanayak

NEW DELHI

Brent has slipped below $90 a barrel for the first time since 31 August. AFP

The Indian economy and oil marketing companies (OMCs) may get some relief as oil prices hover near four-month lows on Tuesday. Around 6:30pm, Brent crude's January contract on the Intercontinental Exchange was trading at $90.22 a barrel, down 2.54% from its previous close. Brent has slipped below $90 a barrel for the first time since 31 August. West Texas Intermediate's December contract on the NYMEX fell 2.06% to $85.07 a barrel.

Experts suggested, however, that concerns persist, as prices are still well above pre-US-Iran war levels. "It is a good thing prices have declined. However, looking at it through the perspective of the budget (FY27) which was presented before the war started, it is still not a comfortable situation, and the pressure continues," said Pronob Sen, former chief statistician of India. Brent was around $70 per barrel on 1 February 2026, when the Union Budget 2026-27 was presented. It was trading at $72 a barrel before the US-Iran war began on 28 February.

"The fiscal impact continues. Due to high oil prices, the initial hit was borne by OMCs, as prices were not increased commensurately. There was, however, some ease as the retail prices were increased (in May). Further, when the government provides compensation or subsidy to OMCs in a bid to provide relief for the impact of high crude prices, then there is a fiscal impact," Sen added. State-run OMCs raised fuel prices by about ₹10 per litre in phases in May.

"If oil prices remain at this level or correct further, it will be beneficial to the economy. Prices of oil byproducts and fertilizers could moderate. Freight rates, too, could fall. All these would help lower inflation. Last but not least, a lower oil import bill could further strengthen the rupee and augur well for the country's current account," said D.K. Pant, chief economist at India Ratings.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Govt to identify rainfed areas to expand cultivation of *chana*

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As many as 80 districts have been identified so far. AP

After India's gram (*chana*) imports fell in FY26 from a record high a year earlier, the government is stepping up efforts to strengthen domestic production of the pulse and further reduce import dependence and keep prices under control.

The department of consumer affairs is identifying rainfed areas that can be brought under *chana* cultivation, two people aware of the matter said.

It has identified 80 districts across states, including Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat, Haryana, Punjab, Jharkhand and Bihar, where rainfed land could be utilized to grow the crop, the people said.

India imported gram worth $3.63 billion in FY26, down from a record $5.54 billion in FY25. The proposed move aims to build on this reduction by expanding domestic chana supplies.

"The government has a tentative estimate of around 2.38 million hectares (mn ha.) of rainfed land across watershed areas in the identified states, and the exact extent of land suitable for chana cultivation will be mapped by the two departments," said the first of the two officials cited above.

"As part of the plan, the department will approach the agriculture ministry and the Department of Land Resources to identify suitable acreage and assess its additional production potential," the official added. The department plans to support farmers with quality seeds and technical assistance, along with procurement assurance, the second official said.

Chana is a relatively less water-intensive crop that can be grown using residual soil moisture after the kharif harvest. The government expects the proposed expansion to strengthen domestic supplies and eventually create scope for chana dal exports, subject to domestic demand and surplus availability.

The average retail price of *chana* dal rose 10.8% year-on-year to ₹90.27 per kg as on 9 November. Domestic *chana* consumption is estimated at 8–8.5 million tonnes (mt) annually, according to industry estimates.

The effort also has implications for food price stability. The RBI's October 2026 Monetary Policy Report noted that pulses inflation stood at 3.6% in August, after the category remained in deflation through much of FY26.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Health workers may soon be certified

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The draft norms require about 900,000 allied health workers to complete bridge courses to retain the right to practice.

Hundreds of thousands of healthcare technicians and allied health workers across India who lack recognized qualifications will now get a chance to formalize their credentials and continue practising, according to draft regulations published by the National Commission for Allied and Healthcare Professions (NCAHP).

The draft regulations, published for feedback and suggestions, require about 900,000 allied health workers with unrecognized qualifications, including medical laboratory technicians, radiographers, physiotherapists and optometrists who account for 60% of India's healthcare workforce, to complete bridge courses and pass an exam to retain their right to practice.

The Provisional Registration of Allied and Healthcare Professionals Regulations, 2026, issued by the NCAHP under the health ministry, outlines a transition pathway for personnel who entered the sector before the NCAHP Act, 2021, took effect. The law was enacted to regulate standards, standardize education and maintain central and state registers across 56 allied healthcare professions in 10 recognized categories such as medical lab sciences, physiotherapy, trauma care and radiology. According to the document, practitioners holding pre-Act experience and matriculation qualifications have two years to apply for provisional registration via state councils for a ₹2,000 fee. Verified applicants will receive a provisional certificate valid for three years with a one-year extension. To earn permanent registration, they must complete approved bridge courses of six months to a year, finish supervised clinical hours and pass a qualifying examination.

The document specifies that completion of the bridge course serves solely for regulatory registration

The document specifies that completion of the bridge course serves solely for regulatory registration—restricting their practice to India—and will not confer an academic degree or diploma.

"The implementation of bridge courses must be practical, affordable and accessible, particularly in smaller towns, while ensuring that certification translates into actual clinical competence," said Dr Chandrakant Lahariya, senior consultant and physician, preventive medicine and cardiometabolic health, at Pacific OneHealth Hospital in New Delhi.

Dr Lahariya said formal training and certification will help improve the reliability of lab tests, imaging and clinical procedures, reducing errors and unnecessary repeat investigations.

However, qualifications alone are insufficient—continuous training, supervision and institutional quality assurance remain essential, he added.

In response to *Mint*'s query, the health ministry said the proposed framework aims to bring uniformity, transparency, and accountability to professional registration while creating structured pathways for practitioners to upgrade their skills.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

MINT SHORTS

Irdai sets up working groups on risk-based capital rules

New Delhi: Insurance regulator Irdai on Tuesday announced setting up two expert panels to prepare a risk-based capital framework aligned with Indian Accounting Standards. Irdai is transitioning the insurance sector to a risk-based capital framework, under which the capital requirement of an insurer is to be commensurate with the risks it carries. PTI

MINT

India, US continue talks to finalize trade deal

New Delhi: India and the US continue to engage in talks for finalizing the first tranche of a proposed trade agreement. A two-member team from the US was in Delhi on 2 and 3 November and the two sides discussed customs and trade facilitation chapter last week in New Delhi, a senior Indian government functionary said on Tuesday.

MANAS PIMPALKHARE & BANIKINKAR PATTANAYAK

EC extends model code curbs to retired govt officials

New Delhi: The Election Commission (EC) on Tuesday said restrictions and prohibitions applicable to serving government employees under the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) will also apply to retired government officials and individuals engaged by state and Union territory governments. In a letter to the chief secretaries and chief electoral officers of Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand, the EC said such individuals must refrain from participating in election campaigns. PTI

MINT

Wheat plantings at record; weather to dictate output

HT

New Delhi: India's wheat planting is expected to reach a record this season but the final output will depend on weather through April-May 2027, which may be influenced by the El Niño, the UN Food and Agriculture Organization said in its latest report. Planting of the crop is under way across the Far East, including India, FAO said in its Crop Prospects and Food Situation report. PTI

Medical devices PLI extended to FY36, rules relaxed

REUTERS

New Delhi: The Centre on Tuesday extended the production-linked incentive (PLI) scheme for domestic manufacturing of medical devices up to 2035-36 and invited fresh applications, the department of pharmaceuticals said in a statement. PRIYANKA SHARMA

Rural jobs lift India's labour market in September quarter

New Delhi: India's labour market improved in the July-September quarter, with unemployment rate across rural and urban India easing to 5.1% in the September quarter, from 5.4% in Q1, driven largely by a seasonal increase in rural employment during the kharif sowing season as per the Periodic Labour Force Survey released on Tuesday. BANIKINKAR PATTANAYAK

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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Printed at HT Media Ltd Plot No. 8, Udyog Vihar, Greater Noida, Distt Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh 201306.
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BSE Sensex		Nifty 50		Nifty 500		Nifty Next 50		Nifty 100		BSE 150 MidCap		BSE 250 SmallCap	
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE
81106.65	7.15	25044.65	6.84	23567.00	5.96	72789.45	5.55	25992.95	6.61	16493.92	4.97	6903.66	3.70
PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE	OPEN
11.91	3.32	11.21	1.93	7.78	-0.61	6.78	-2.55	10.38	1.09	3.61	-4.33	0.30	-4.65
HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW	HIGH	LOW
4.89	-2.54	3.59	-1.76	1.95	0.19	1.81	4.94	3.28	-0.58	-0.87	1.07	-0.67	1.29

Tata Steel's local biz shines in Q2

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Tata Steel's consolidated Ebitda grew 18% year-on-year to ₹10,500 crore in the September quarter (Q2FY27), supported by improved realization and higher volumes in the domestic business.

Revenue from the domestic and overseas business increased 11% to ₹65,450 crore even as sales volume was flat at 7.92 million tonnes. European operations reported strong realization growth, but profit declined as lower volumes hurt operating leverage.

With this, the first half (H1) of fiscal year 2027 revenue and Ebitda growth stand at 13% and 21%, respectively. The second half of FY27 could be better, with the management expecting volumes to pick up and prices to remain at higher levels.

Domestic realizations in Q3 are expected to be about ₹3,500 per tonne higher than ₹70,400 reported in Q2, which was flattish sequentially, but up 14% y-o-y. This would be partly offset by an about $15 per tonne sequential rise in the cost of coking coal. Ongoing annual contract negotiations in Europe, amid the firm pricing environment, should reflect from Q4 or Q1FY28.

Tata Steel's standalone Ebitda, which includes its domestic operations, grew 23% y-o-y to ₹10,315 crore. The overseas businesses were subdued as lower sales volumes offset the benefit of 33% and 16% y-o-y growth in realizations in the UK and the Netherlands, respectively.

Volumes in the Netherlands contributed 16% of consolidated sales in Q2, but Ebitda dipped 14% y-o-y to ₹790 crore, though much higher than QI's ₹39 crore, which was hurt by the shutdown of its direct sheet plant in April following breach of environment norms.

While the plant restarted in August, the Netherlands business continues to face uncertainty over its high emissions. The management expects greater clarity by March on the government's support for decarbonization investments and the business' long-term viability.

The UK contributes 5% of Tata Steel's total volumes and remained in losses, albeit lower at ₹719 crore against ₹764 crore a year ago. Volumes were impacted by higher imports and inventory build-up by domestic consumers ahead of the implementation of trade measures from 1 July.

The management expects the inventory overhang to persist till Q4, which could stay longer for some product categories. It is targeting Ebitda breakeven in the UK by Q4, aided by higher prices, a pick-up in volumes and cost savings.

While the near-term earnings prospects look robust, given the firm steel price outlook, volume growth could be a challenge.

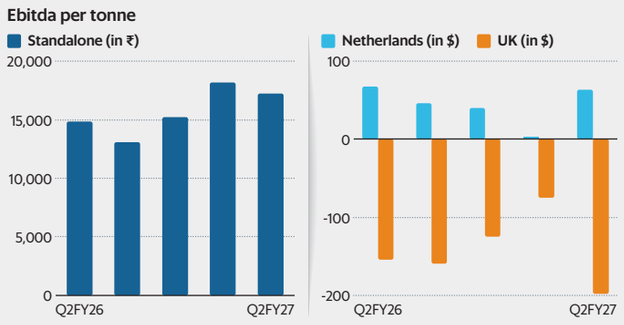
"With the next 5 mtpa (million tonne per annum) rise coming up only by FY31, Tata Steel will deliver lacklustre volume growth over FY28-30," said Jefferies India.

The brokerage, nevertheless, raised its FY27-29 earnings per share estimates by 2-5% and retained its 'buy' rating on the stock. The 3.2 mtpa electric arc furnace project in the UK is expected to start in 2029, after delays due to power connection and other infrastructure issues.

Tata Steel shares have fallen almost 18% from its 52-week high of ₹224.4 on 15 May, dragged down by the environmental headwinds in the Netherlands. The stock trades at an enterprise value of 7.4 times its FY27 estimated Ebitda, as per *Bloomberg*. Greater clarity on the future of the Netherlands operations remains crucial for the stock.

Mixed fortune

Domestic operations drove Tata Steel's Q2FY27 profitability, but overseas business was dull due to lower sales volumes.



Ebitda is earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization; Standalone includes domestic business

Source: Company, Nuvama Research

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

FOREIGN PERIL

TATA Steel's overseas business hit by lower sales volumes despite higher realizations

THE Netherlands business continues to face uncertainty over its high emissions

Axis Bank bets on AI to lift digital loan conversions

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Axis Bank's Sameer Shetty says the lender's AI guide plan is right now in development.

Axis Bank is building an artificial intelligence (AI) assistant to guide customers through online loan applications, aiming to convert more browsers into borrowers.

Currently, of every 100 people who start a personal loan application with India's third-largest private-sector lender, only 8 complete the process and have their money disbursed, according to Sameer Shetty, group head of digital business and transformation and strategic programmes, Axis Bank. The bank believes adding an interactive AI guide could raise that completion rate to between 12% and 15%.

"This is right now in development," Shetty said. The former McKinsey & Co. executive who joined the bank in 2019, noted that most applicants walk away long before approval, not because the bank rejects them, but because they get anxious about interest rates, worry about hidden fees, or simply want someone to negotiate with. Since the online application process is entirely automated, there's usually no one available to clear up those doubts.

To support the shift, Axis raised tech spending to 10% of operating expenses from 8.5% three years ago

The feature arrives as the bank pushes more digital borrowing. Fully digital originations accounted for 84% of Axis's personal loan payouts in the September quarter, pushing its overall personal loan portfolio to ₹84,954 crore, an 8% jump year-over-year. To support the shift, Axis has steadily increased its tech budget, which now swallows 10% of operating expenses, up from 8.5% three years ago. The bank does not disclose the quarterly disbursement numbers.

"Once the solution is active, customers can ask the agent whether he/she can get a better rate. The answer may be yes or no, or the agent could say, look, this is why the rate is so and so for you and then try to convince the customer," said Shetty.

Shetty said that the 8% conversion rate is very good for end-to-end digital lending right now but can be improved with AI-led support. He said that for branches, the conversion rate is much higher because someone is available to speak with and answer customer queries.

Experts now believe that AI could be proactively used to enhance customer relationships. A June report by the World Economic Forum and Accenture said that with analytical and generative capabilities now widely accessible, organizations that intentionally use AI to strengthen customer relationships will be better positioned to deliver superior experiences, deepen retention, and drive growth.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

LG Electronics is moving beyond its two-track strategy

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LG Electronics India's Q2FY27 results has strengthened its growth narrative, even as the road ahead opens up new avenues.

Revenue grew almost 20% year-on-year to ₹7,380 crore, while Ebitda margin expanded 63 basis points (bps) to 9.5%. A richer product mix and operating leverage more than offset elevated commodity prices and higher go-to-market investments.

LG's two-track strategy of premiumization and mass-premium penetration continued to deliver broad-based growth. Home appliances and air solutions revenue grew 21% to ₹4,772 crore, with double-digit growth across washing machines, refrigerators and air conditioners. Home entertainment revenue grew 17% to ₹2,608 crore, marking its third consecutive quarter of double-digit growth. Televisions larger than 55 inches led the segment, contributing over half of TV revenue.

Premiumization through products such as French-door refrigerators and large-capacity washing machines can improve the product mix, even as LG's Essential series strengthens volume growth, helps capture first-time buyers, creates an upgrade pipeline for premium products and enables expansion into international markets.

The company's global presence has expanded to 68 countries, while its information display business has opened up B2B opportunities across corporate offices, retail, hospitality and public spaces.

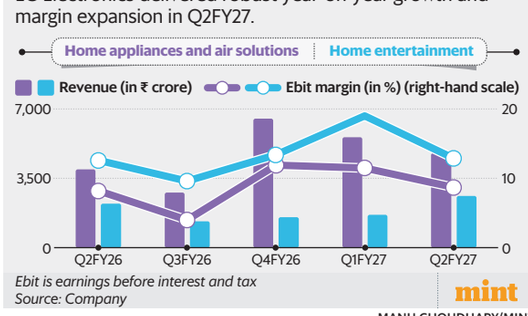
Its entry into vehicle solutions, spanning telematics, automotive displays, digital cockpits and connectivity solutions, opens up another B2B opportunity. Manufacturing at its Sri City facility can leverage LG's established global technology and manufacturing ecosystem.

But much depends on sustaining margins. Raw material costs rose 20% year-on-year, leading to a 52 bps fall in gross margin. Currency volatility and competition also pose risks. The 300 bps sequential fall in Ebitda margin also needs tracking.

LG's management expects H2FY27 to outperform H1, retaining its guidance of mid-teens revenue growth and early double-digit Ebitda margins. The stock has gained 21% this year, and is testing its all-time high of ₹1,836 while ICICI Securities has upgraded its target price to ₹2,100 from ₹1,850 on hopes that strong execution, improving product mix and upcoming manufacturing capacity at Sri City position LG favourably to sustain industry-beating growth.

Dual engines

LG Electronics delivered robust year-on-year growth and margin expansion in Q2FY27.



Ebit is earnings before interest and tax
Source: Company

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Retail investors turn selective, flock to Reliance, HDFC Bank

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Small investors are becoming pickier about the stocks they own. In the September quarter, they reduced their stakes in nearly half of listed companies, even as Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank and PC Jeweller drew more retail shareholders.

A *Mint* analysis of 4,729 BSE-listed companies showed retail ownership (those holding up to ₹1 lakh in equity) declined in 49.4% of companies in the second quarter (Q2) of fiscal year 2027 (FY27), up from 47.5% in Q1FY27. The proportion recording an increase slipped to 42.4% from 43.2%, while 8.2% saw no change, according to ACE Equity data.

Vedant Gupte, co-founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of investment platform Trackk, interprets the divergence as portfolio pruning. "We read the September-quarter data as a clean-up of portfolios, not a loss of faith," he said.

The key test is whether Reliance and HDFC Bank retain shareholders as stock interest fades

He sees two strands of buying: established businesses at more attractive valuations, and riskier momentum or turnaround bets. The disclosures, however, do not establish whether the same investors moved money between these groups.

Four companies together recorded more than a million net retail shareholder additions in the September quarter. Reliance led with 401,762, followed by HDFC Bank with 273,525, PC Jeweller with 242,298 and Cupid with 173,458. The additions may include investors holding multiple companies.

BSE added 161,456 retail shareholders, while Coal India added 151,579. Elsewhere, Bajaj Auto lost 353,533, IDFC First Bank 138,832 and Wipro 103,653.

Gupte described BSE as a momentum bet and PC Jeweller as a turnaround opportunity.

"Appetite for risk hasn't disappeared. It has moved into fewer, more specific bets," he said, cautioning that turnaround hopes can disappoint and momentum can reverse quickly.

That distinction was visible at Reliance, where additions accelerated ahead of Jio Platforms' initial public offering (IPO).

Reliance added 204,923 retail shareholders in March quarter and 219,986 in June quarter, before additions nearly doubled to 401,762 in September quarter. Its retail base reached 4.87 million, up about 9% sequentially, while ownership edged up to 7.24% from 7.16%.

Reliance shares fell 8.3% in the September quarter, compared with a 5.2% fall in the Sensex.

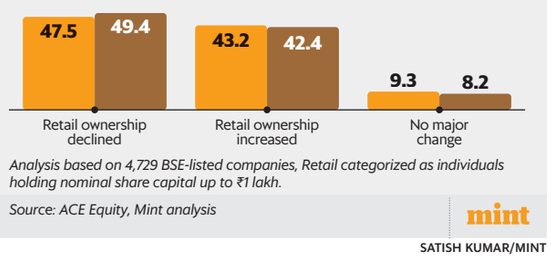
HDFC Bank shares fell 11.2% in the September quarter.

For Gupte, the test is whether shareholder numbers hold up in Reliance and HDFC Bank, and whether interest in momentum and turnaround stocks fades when prices cool.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Picky stakes

Retail investors cut stakes in nearly half of listed firms, even as select stocks gained shareholders.



Analysis based on 4,729 BSE-listed companies, Retail categorized as individuals holding nominal share capital up to ₹1 lakh.

Source: ACE Equity, Mint analysis

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SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Sugar mills face ethanol margin squeeze

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Indian sugar mills are staring at a 140-160 basis-point contraction in operating margins this fiscal as restrictions on ethanol production from sugar-based feedstocks erode a key source of higher-margin earnings, while rising sugarcane costs and increased funding requirements add to the pressure, according to Crisil Ratings.

Operating margins are expected to decline to around 6% this fiscal, despite an anticipated 4-5% growth in operating income, as firm sugar prices and steady demand prove insufficient to offset the adverse product mix, higher input costs and increased interest burden. The squeeze follows a significant policy shift. For ethanol supply year (ESY) 2027, ethanol production from sugarcane-based feedstocks has effectively been restricted to C-heavy molasses, sharply curtailing mills' ability to divert sugar towards higher-margin ethanol production. In recent years, nearly 10% of gross sugar output was routinely diverted to ethanol, according to Crisil.

Ethanol production from C-heavy molasses will offer only limited relief, with administered prices remaining unchanged over the past three years.

Oil, rural stress cloud FMCG outlook

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India's top consumer goods companies are heading into a challenging second half of the fiscal year, with rising input costs, pressure on margins and uneven demand threatening to erode the gains from volume growth in the September quarter. While companies managed to expand revenues and volumes through selective price hikes and product-mix changes, analysts warn that sustaining growth without further margin pressure will be difficult.

The challenge is compounded by the prospect of crude oil prices remaining elevated until the US and Iran reach a lasting peace agreement. Drought conditions in several parts of the country, meanwhile, threaten rural incomes and could weigh on demand for consumer goods, adding to the pressures facing the sector.

Results for the quarter ended 30 September 2026 show how companies are balancing the competing demands of protecting market share and preserving profitability. Some chose to absorb higher input costs to sustain volumes, while others resorted to phased price increases or changes in product mix to defend margins.

Crude oil has emerged as a major source of cost pressure. Its derivatives are used across the consumer goods industry in transportation, fuel, plastic packaging and surfactants for detergents. Crude prices rose 34% between the end of February, when the US-Iran war began, and the end of September. Analysts caution that the balance between volume growth and margins could come under further pressure in the second half, particularly as growth in the first half was largely price-led.

"There will be volumetric headline challenges in the coming two quarters, and the factors will be both external and internal," said Rishi Agarwal, partner at PwC India. Crude prices are among the key external pressures this season. "Margins are fundamentally going to be constrained by factors which are not in companies' control, whether it is laminates, sulphur, agricultural commodities or the entire crude basket," he said.

The challenge is prolonged crude price pressure until the US and Iran reach a lasting peace agreement

Market leader Hindustan Unilever Ltd (HUL) prioritized volume recovery, passing on only absolute cost increases rather than raising prices aggressively. The strategy helped it protect market share while limiting pressure on margins. HUL reported underlying volume growth of 7%, its highest in 21 quarters. The company also cut advertising and promotion (A&P) spending by 9.3% year-on-year to ₹1,481 crore in the September quarter, helping contain the impact of rising costs on its bottom line.

"Input cost comes fast and price takes time to catch up," said Priya Nair, HUL's chief executive officer, explaining the lag between rising input costs and retail price adjustments. Chief financial officer Niranjan Gupta defended the volume-first approach: "You can recover margin in a hurry. You don't recover market share and growth in a hurry."

Tata Consumer Products Ltd (TCPL) followed a similar approach, reporting 11% volume growth in its domestic business, while consolidated Ebitda margin stood at 14%. To offset higher input costs in salt and tea, the company introduced phased price increases, raising the price of Tata Salt from ₹30 to ₹34 a pack and increasing tea prices by 8-10%.

The outlook for the second half is also clouded by concerns over rural consumption.

"H2 would have a bit more cautious approach on the south-west monsoon ending about 13% below its long-period average, with El Niño and low reservoirs threatening rabi sowing," said Tanvi Kanchan, Associate Director, Anand Rathi Share & Stock Brokers. Lower crude may support urban spending," Kanchan said.

In contrast, Marico showed how lower raw material costs in key categories can aid both volume growth and margin expansion. With copra prices remaining range-bound at roughly 35% below their peak, the company reported a 13% volume increase for Parachute, its strongest growth in 22 quarters.

Still, analysts warn that the sector's volume-margin equilibrium faces stress in the second half of the financial year.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Balancing act

Consumer goods companies have been trying to protect margins as raw material prices rise.

Details of select FMCG companies (in %), Jul-Sep 2026

	Ebitda margin	Year-on-year growth in volume
Hindustan Unilever	22.6	7
Emami	20.4	26
Godrej Consumer Products	18.7	8
Britannia Industries	18.2	13
Marico	18.2	10
Dabur India	17.8	5.5
Tata Consumer Products	14.0	11

Ebitda: Earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization. Emami's volume growth is on a like-to-like basis.

Source: Company filings

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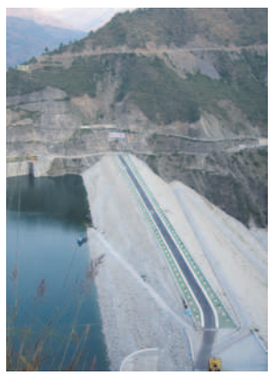
Dr. Krishna Kumar Birla

November 11, 1918 - August 30, 2008.

Depleting dams cast a cloud over crops, hydropower

FROM PAGE 1


Tehri dam in Uttarakhand has generation capacity of 1GW. MINT

could be unprecedented in strength, potentially taking Pacific Ocean temperatures 3.8°C above average, with its peak expected towards the end of 2026 and climate impacts extending well into 2027. For India, it means below-normal rainfall, higher temperatures and prolonged drought conditions. India's southwest monsoon rainfall in 2026 stood at 87% of the 50-year average, making it the fourth-lowest since 2001 and the 13th-lowest since 1901, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). October saw a rainfall deficit of 31.4%.

Late October, Maharashtra expanded drought relief to 305 of its 358 talukas and approved a ₹7,500-crore package, including ₹5,000 aid for eligible farmers.

The energy sector may feel the impact too. While coal dominates the power sector, hydropower plays a key role in supporting solar and wind power. Turbines can be quickly turned on and off; so, hydropower can step in when the sun doesn't shine and the wind doesn't blow.

Crops were sown across 11.7 million hectares till 6 Nov, 2.43 million hectares below last year's 14.1 million at this time

"In the case of run-of-the-river hydro projects, the lesser discharge of water may impact hydropower generation and the decline in reservoir levels would also bring hydro power generation below what is generally witnessed during these months," said Raj Kumar Chaudhary, former chairman and managing director, NHPC Ltd.

India has 20 reservoir-based hydropower projects, monitored by the CWC. Gobind Sagar dam in Himachal Pradesh, with a generation capacity of 1.3GW, had storage of 56.87% of the full reservoir level (FRL) as of 5 November, compared to 85.09% in the corresponding period last year. It is also way below its 10-year average of 73.52%. Similarly, the reservoir level in the Koyna dam (1.9GW) in Maharashtra is currently at 87.67% of the full reservoir level, while last year it was at 100%. The current level in Tehri dam (1GW) in Uttarakhand is 92.91%, compared to 95.28% last year.

Chaudhary added that heating demand may add to overall consumption. The former NHPC chief noted that although solar and thermal would play a key role in these winter months, pollution and heavy smog in northern states could impact solar power generation in the region, affecting overall power supply.

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For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

India Inc sees the quiet rise of non-permanent workers

Volatile demand, cost woes are prompting firms to reassess their workforce commitments

Abhinaba Saha & Niti Kiran
MUMBAI

Business uncertainty is reshaping how India Inc hires, with the preference for a stable, permanent workforce giving way to more flexible employment arrangements. Volatile demand, geopolitical disruptions, artificial intelligence (AI)-led restructuring and mounting cost pressures are prompting companies to reassess their long-term workforce commitments.

A *Mint* analysis of 353 BSE 500 companies found that non-permanent employees accounted for 17% of the workforce at these companies in FY26, up from around 11% in FY23. The analysis draws on comparable data from annual reports between FY23 and FY26. Non-permanent employees include fixed-term employees, contract workers and gig workers, as distinct from permanent, on-roll staff.

For companies, such arrangements offer the flexibility to adjust staffing levels as business needs change. However, workers face uncertainty over statutory benefits and career progression, while employers risk losing institutional knowledge and operational continuity as their reliance on temporary staff grows.

Non-permanent employment broadly covers fixed-term employees hired directly by companies for a specified tenure, and contract workers who work at company premises but remain on the payrolls of third-party contractors, said Atul Gupta, partner, labour and employment practice at Trilegal.

Such workers can be hired quickly and, more importantly, disengaged without the more elaborate procedures involved in terminating permanent employees, Gupta said.

The arrangements, however, carry different implications for workers. Fixed-term employees are generally entitled to wages and statutory benefits comparable to those of permanent staff, though their contracts end automatically on expiry. Contract workers, by contrast, may receive lower wages and benefits, although the law mandates pay parity for those doing the same or similar work, said Suchita Dutta, executive director, Indian Staffing Federation.

As repetitive roles disappear and demand shifts towards technical and specialized skills, employees will increasingly need to reskill to remain relevant, Dutta said.

The new Labour Codes seek to alter some of these dynamics by restricting the use of contract labour in core business activities, subject to specified exceptions, Gupta said. This could push companies towards direct employment for certain roles, although they are still assessing which activities qualify as core functions and how the restrictions will affect their hiring models.

"A true test of whether the Labour Codes have helped change this ratio and increase the share of permanent employees would be to conduct similar surveys for the financial years ending 2027 and 2028," Gupta said.

Rising business costs could further accelerate the shift towards non-permanent employment, Dutta said. Domestic companies saw overall costs rise 22% year-on-year in the September quarter (Q2), following a 23% increase in the June quarter, according to a *Mint* analysis of Q2FY27 results of 1,750 listed companies. Overall costs are at a three-year high, with crude oil averaging above $95 a barrel this year, compared with $68 in 2025, amid the West Asia war.

Profitability is also under strain. Companies excluding banks, financial services, insurance and oil marketing companies reported a net profit margin of 11.9% in the September quarter so far, down from 12.8% in the previous quarter and below the four-year average of 12.2%, the analysis showed. With cost pressures expected to persist and limited scope for further price increases, analysts expect profitability to weaken further.

"When margins come under pressure, one of the first things companies reconsider is their commitment to long-term employment," Dutta said.

While flexible staffing can offer immediate cost and operational benefits, it could discourage investment in training and retention, eroding institutional knowledge and continuity of skills within organizations, said Charu Malhotra, co-founder and managing director of consulting firm Primus Partners.

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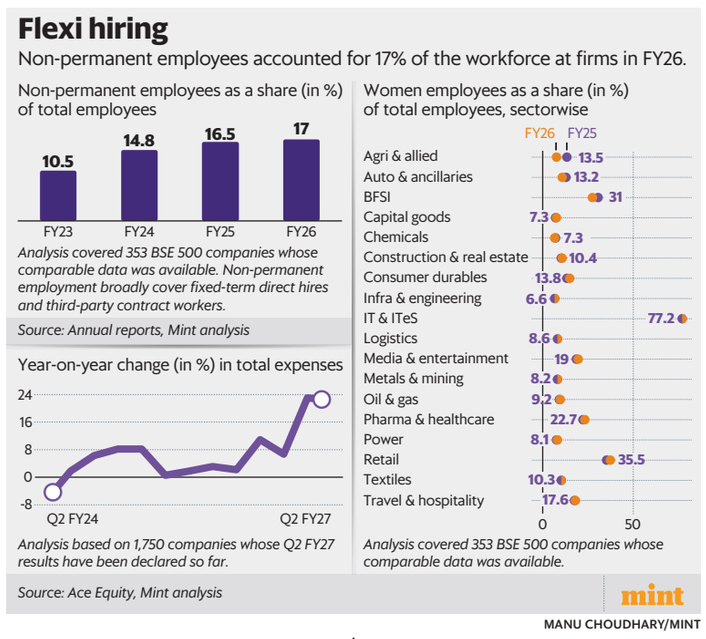
Rushi Gupta and Mayur Bhalerao contributed to this story.

This is the second part of a three-part data series based on annual reports. The first part examined how long India Inc.'s corner-office leaders stay at the helm.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

WORKFORCE SHIFT

PREFERENCE for a stable, permanent workforce is giving way to more flexible hiring arrangements

AS repetitive roles vanish, employees will increasingly need to reskill to remain relevant

RISING business costs could boost the shift towards non-permanent employment

LOCAL firms saw overall costs rise 22% y-o-y in Sep quarter, following a 23% rise in the Jun quarter

Sadaf Sayeed, MD and CEO, Muthoot Microfin.

Muthoot Microfin raises IT spending by 40%

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Muthoot Microfin Ltd has raised its information technology (IT) spending by 40% this fiscal year to boost cybersecurity and digital infrastructure as artificial intelligence (AI)-assisted attacks increasingly target financial institutions, managing director and chief executive Sadaf Sayeed told *Mint*.

"We've made a huge amount of investment in our security systems to ensure that there is no data leakage and there is no kind of intrusion into our application system," Sayeed said. The company's application system is developed in-house and hosted on a private cloud, with multiple layers of security, he added.

The investments come amid heightened cybersecurity concerns. On 4 November, the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the home ministry, and the Indian Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-In), under the ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY), warned banks, non-banking financial companies and fintechs of an escalation in AI-led cyberattacks.

Muthoot has around 3.2 million customers, with 2.2 million using its app, Sayeed said. The lender is will continue investing in tech and security systems.

The lender said it is seeing a shift in rural consumption, with households spending more on nutrition and better-quality products, including milk and dairy, This could improve health and productivity, supporting income generation and repayment capacity.

Sayeed attributed rising formal credit to government financial inclusion push and expansion of all banks, microfinance and fintech firms into underserved markets.

Its assets under management rose 22% year-on-year to ₹15,322 crore in July-September. Disbursements rose 27% to ₹2,900 crore, up 10% sequentially. Net profit rose to ₹110.8 crore from about ₹30 crore a year ago.

Gross non-performing assets (GNPA) fell 32 basis points to 3.38%, and Sayeed sees GNPA at 2.5-2.75% by end FY27, with sub 1% net NPA.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Foreign regulators quiz firms on data

FROM PAGE 1

The DPDP Act was enacted in August 2023. ISTOCKPHOTO

under that jurisdiction's laws.

The information sought can include customer and employee records, know-your-customer (KYC) and transaction data, internal emails and chats, audit papers, investigation documents, financial records and operational data. Financial services, technology and outsourcing, pharmaceuticals and life sciences are among the sectors exposed to such demands.

Mayuran Palanisamy, partner at Deloitte India, said companies are asking what personal data they hold, where it is stored, whether it can be disclosed to an overseas regulator, and what confidentiality, localization, or sector-specific restrictions may apply. "The questions we are seeing are increasingly around how to operationalize compliance, rather than only how to interpret the law," he said.

The issue has gained importance as India's data protection regime moves towards full implementation. The DPDP Act was enacted in August 2023, and the rules were notified in November 2025. Key provisions on cross-border data will take effect in May.

The framework allows the government to prescribe additional conditions or restrictions on transfers of certain categories of personal data, while sectoral regulators can impose their own requirements.

Companies are preparing for the cross-border provisions of India's DPDP law to take effect in May 2027

For instance, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) requires payment system data to be stored in India, while allowing such data to be shared with an overseas regulator, subject to RBI nod and depending on nature or origin of the transaction. And then, Section 16 of the DPDP Act permits transfers of personal data outside India, subject to curbs the government may impose on specific countries or territories.

Palanisamy said companies are looking at privacy compliance alongside sectoral regulations, confidentiality, retention, security and contractual obligations.

According to Supratim Chakraborty, partner at Khaitan & Co., companies need to assess the scope and legal basis of the request, the nature of the information sought and whether disclosure is subject to protections under Indian law, particularly where it involves personal data, commercially sensitive information or confidential records.

Narasimhan Elangovan, co-founder, practice head - cyber security and data privacy at Ascentium India, said the information sought can vary by sector.

Financial firms may face requests for transaction and payment records, technology firms for customer or employee data, telecom operators for subscriber information, and healthcare and pharma firms for patient, manufacturing or lab records.

Cyber and data privacy experts said that until the DPDP provisions come into force, companies will continue to rely on existing laws.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

JSW gives latest airport bids a miss, as assets fail viability test

FROM PAGE 1

JSW sees the smaller airports on offer as unviable. REUTERS

size. It is not viable for us, so it doesn't make sense... If and when Kolkata and Chennai airports come to play, we may review our decision," he said.

India's private airports are operated by two major conglomerates, led by the Adani Group that runs eight airports, including Mumbai and Navi Mumbai, and GMR Airports, which operates six including Delhi, Hyderabad and Goa. Government-owned AAI manages 137 airports, including 24 international ones.

India's top six airports hosted 60% of the air traffic in FY26. They were led by New Delhi that handled 78.7 million passengers, followed by Mumbai (55.3 million). Bengaluru (44.47 million), Hyderabad (30.48 million), Chennai (23.3 million) and Kolkata (22 million) were the others.

"Airport entry has a credible strategic logic. JSW's port experience provides relevant capabilities in financing, project execution, concession management and government coordination," said Saptarshi Purkayastha, professor of strategic management at the Indian Institute of Management Calcutta.

JSW Infrastructure is India's second-largest private port and terminal operator.

"However, metropolitan airports require additional expertise in passenger services, airline relationships, security compliance and commercial revenues. Dedicated airport leadership, an experienced operating partner and carefully phased commitments would strengthen the case. The attractiveness of airports ultimately depends on terms of entry and the capabilities JSW builds," he said.

Entering the airport sector was part of JSW's broader search for opportunities beyond its traditional steel business. It has expanded into power, infrastructure, cement, paints and real estate.

"I see this as an acceleration of JSW's evolution into a diversified industrial group, with steel continuing as its anchor," said Purkayastha. He said success will depend on how well the group manages its expanding portfolio.

The expansion brings JSW into a growing overlap with Adani in ports, cement and potentially, airports. "The overlaps suggest JSW and Adani will increasingly encounter each other in infrastructure auctions and acquisitions," he added.

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Democrats are investigating the biggest American companies

FROM PAGE 1

warned all of the recipients that failure to respond on time—Jan. 4 at the latest—would leave him "no choice but to consider alternative measures to obtain compliance."

Democrats on the Senate Banking Committee have also been quick to telegraph their targets. On the eve of the election, they released a report titled "Nine Ways Trump's Corruption Is Costing You," naming Toyota, Walmart, Live Nation and major banks among companies that allegedly received favorable treatment from the government after contributing to Trump's inauguration.

Separately, the House Judiciary Committee has started to reach out to lawyers who were involved in an antitrust lawsuit against Live Nation, which senior officials at the Justice Department settled at Trump's direction. The deal was hammered out at the White House with the involvement of Live Nation's lawyers at Sullivan & Cromwell, which represents Trump in some of his personal litigation.

A Live Nation spokeswoman said the settlement terms adequately address the antitrust claims made in the government's lawsuit. "We're ready to walk any policymaker through how and why it was reached," the spokeswoman said.

The Democrat set to chair the judiciary committee, Jamie Raskin, has also said he is ready to subpoena law firms that struck deals with the Trump administration promising to do pro bono work for the president's favored causes to neutralize punitive executive orders.

One reason Democrats are focusing on businesses is that it could provide an easier way for investigators trying to access information about the Trump administration. Companies have taken pains not to put themselves on the wrong side of the White House but now potentially face difficult questions about turning over their correspondence with Trump officials.

"It's going to put companies between a rock and a hard place," said James Bair, a former congressional investigator who is now a partner at Crowell & Moring.

Some of America's largest firms—from Amazon to Apple, Live Nation to Walmart—are among the first to feel the heat. REUTERS

Democrats on key committees have been laying the groundwork for weeks and even months, dispatching targeted document-preservation requests to companies across the tech, energy, aerospace and healthcare sectors. Companies have responded with caution.

Jared Huffman, the most senior Democrat on the House Natural Resources Committee, in late August sent preservation requests to two dozen companies listed as corporate sponsors or partners of Freedom 250 LLC, the Trump-aligned group that organized the nation's 250th celebrations, including the Freedom 250 Grand Prix race held in Washington, D.C. Those companies included Chevron, Exxon, Lockheed Martin, Mastercard, Oracle, United Airlines and UnitedHealth Group.

Some of the companies sent a short response, acknowledging receipt, according to people familiar with the communications. They talked informally among themselves, wondering if the committee's jurisdictional hook—linking the Washington, D.C., race to the lawmaker's Department of Interior oversight—was a stretch. Other companies turned over documents, one of the people said.

Democratic investigators are also scrutinizing data-analysis company Palantir over contracts with the Department of Homeland Security.

Big questions remain about how Democrats will handle their regained power, including how strictly congressional leaders will try to ensure that different committees stay out of each others' lanes and stick to issues that resonate with voters.

Even companies that have been "out of the spotlight" are wondering if they could be pulled into oversight hearings, given the size of the Democratic majority, said Brandon Farris, executive vice president at the Steel Manufacturers Association.

When Democrats had their stint in the House majority during Trump's first term, many within the party and in legal circles saw Congress as overextending itself with too many targets and wasting valuable time with protracted court fights, said Robert Kelner, a partner at Covington & Burling who heads the firm's congressional-investigations group.

The magnitude of Democrats' victories also means companies "will have fewer allies," Kelner said. "The scale means that congressional Democrats will be maximally incentivized to aggressively pursue companies in investigations."

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MINT SHORTS

Microsoft presses Trump to scuttle plan to ban China data centre tech

Washington: Microsoft has been pressing the Trump administration to halt plans to bar Chinese imports of a key component used in artificial intelligence data centres, three people familiar with the situation said. *Reuters* reported in August that the Trump administration wants to ban US imports of new models of Chinese optical transceivers, which allow data to travel over fibre-optic cables at the speed of light within data centres. The concern is that they could be used by Beijing to steal data, install malware or disrupt service at US data centres. **REUTERS**

SoftBank logs $7 billion loss as US data centre costs swell

REUTERS

SoftBank Group Corp. reported its first net loss in almost two years after swallowing a $3.7 billion writedown over its US data centre projects amid rising fears around the sustainability of artificial intelligence (AI) growth. The Tokyo-based backer of OpenAI tumbled to a ¥1.12 trillion ($7.1 billion) loss in its fiscal second quarter after shouldering non-refundable advance payments related to power generation at projects including an ambitious Ohio data centre push. Analysts on average expected a profit of ¥129 billion. **BLOOMBERG**

TSMC to invest up to $500 million each in Anthropic, OpenAI

Taipei: Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. Ltd's (TSMC) board has approved an investment of up to $500 million to acquire Anthropic's common shares at its initial public offering (IPO) share price as well as up to $500 million to acquire OpenAI's preferred stock, a statement from the Taiwanese chipmaker said on Tuesday. **REUTERS**

KKR seeks investor in power firm ContourGlobal at £4 billion value

KKR & Co. is seeking a co-investor for ContourGlobal in a deal that could value the independent power producer at as much as £4 billion ($5.4 billion) including debt, people with knowledge of the matter said. **BLOOMBERG**

Blackstone picks up 16% in IIFL Finance for ₹5,000 cr

The deal, part of a ₹6,414-crore fundraise, marks a major private equity bet on NBFC sector

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The investment will be made via convertible preference shares at ₹602 apiece, converting into equity within 18 months. BLOOMBERG

Blackstone, the world's largest alternative asset manager, will invest ₹5,000 crore in IIFL Finance Ltd for a stake of about 16% on a fully diluted basis, as the non-banking financial company (NBFC) looks to strengthen its balance sheet and expand its lending business.

IIFL announced the investment on Tuesday as part of a ₹6,414-crore capital raise, marking one of India's largest private equity infusions into a listed Indian NBFC.

The announcement came after market hours. Shares of IIFL Finance closed 0.5% lower at ₹626.65, while benchmark Nifty 50 ended 0.2% higher.

Blackstone's investment, equivalent to $535 million, will be made through compulsorily convertible preference shares (CCPS) that will convert into equity shares at ₹602 apiece, in line with regulatory pricing requirements, within 18 months of allotment.

Earlier in the day, *The Economic Times* (ET) reported that Blackstone was preparing to acquire a 15% stake for ₹5,000 crore, with promoters Nirmal Jain and R. Venkataraman investing around ₹1,200 crore to maintain their combined holding at around 25%. The report also said that Mumbai-based investor Rohit Kothari, through Anchorage Capital, would participate in the transaction.

Under the final structure, Jain and Venkataraman will invest ₹1,264 crore through preferentially allotted warrants, while Anchorage Capital will contribute another ₹150 crore through a primary equity investment, the company said.

The capital infusion is expected to significantly strengthen IIFL Finance's balance sheet, with its capital adequacy ratio projected to rise from about 17% to 30% on a pro forma September 2026 basis.

The additional capital will support IIFL's expansion across its secured lending businesses, particularly gold finance, and could improve credit ratings and reduce borrowing costs over time, said the company.

"We are delighted to welcome Blackstone as a partner in IIFL Finance. Their investment is a strong endorsement of the franchise our team has built," said Nirmal Jain, founder and managing director of IIFL Finance.

He said the partnership would provide the company with the headroom to scale its businesses, invest further in technology and deepen co-lending partnerships with banks while maintaining risk discipline.

The deal comes amid IIFL Finance's improving operating performance. Its consolidated assets under management (AUM) was at ₹1.24 trillion as of 30 September, up 38% year-on-year. Net revenues were at ₹2,340 crore, while profit after tax before minority interest rose 93% to ₹805 crore.

The NBFC's gross non-performing assets ratio improved to 1.48% from 2.14% a year ago, while return on equity was at 20.8%. Gold loans accounted for 52.9% of the consolidated loan AUM at ₹65,729 crore, up 90% year-on-year.

The Blackstone transaction comes after months of negotiations with potential investors. *ET* had reported that Advent International, TPG and Temasek were among those exploring the investment. The company had last raised equity capital through a ₹1,272-crore rights issue in May 2024.

The proposed transaction remains subject to customary regulatory and shareholder approvals.

CAPITAL INFUSION

- **THE** deal gives IIFL Finance a stronger capital base to expand its secured lending business
- **THE** additional capital will support IIFL's expansion across its secured lending businesses
- **THE** deal comes amid IIFL Finance's improving operating performance—its AUM rose 38% in Q2
- **THE** Blackstone transaction comes after months of negotiations with potential investors

Resolven in talks for $219 mn fundraise

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Swedish private equity firm EQT-backed renewable energy platform Resolven, carved out of Spanish company Zelestra's India business in February, has mobilized around $900 million in financing since becoming an independent company.

The company is in advanced stages of closing $219.5 million (approximately ₹2,100 crore) in financing for 400 megawatts of wind-solar hybrid projects from financing institutions, it said in a statement on Wednesday.

It added that about $700 million is fund-based debt financing, and $200 million is group-level non-fund lines. These financings have been mobilized from a diversified set of 15 lenders spanning public sector banks, private banks, MNC banks and infrastructure financing institutions.

"In March 2026, the company's financing journey began with the closing of ₹450 crore refinancing of its 136MW operating assets with an infrastructure debt fund, which reduced the company's interest costs and locked in fixed rates in a volatile environment," it said.

Over the past few quarters, Resolven has secured financing for 1 GW of multi-technology firm and dispatchable renewable energy (FDRE) and hybrid renewable projects. The funding comprises a mix of rupee-denominated loans and external commercial borrowings (ECBs).

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Dun & Bradstreet sees India AI growth amid talent lag

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Dun & Bradstreet, a global data and analytics firm, sees growing opportunities in India as artificial intelligence (AI) unlocks new capabilities for businesses across sectors and of varying sizes, its top executives told *Mint* in an interview.

The firm's survey of more than 10,000 businesses globally, including around 300 in India, found that AI adoption in the country has increased, with further headroom for growth as businesses gain better access to reliable data.

Nearly seven in 10 Indian businesses plan to increase spending on AI over the next 12 months, while 30% report broad or strong returns from their AI initiatives, according to the firm's latest AI Momentum survey.

"Given the capabilities available today and the potential of AI, it is critical to put appropriate guardrails and governance frameworks in place to ensure that the necessary controls are established," said Julian Prower, Dun & Bradstreet's managing director and chief executive officer (CEO) for India and Taiwan.

The survey, which spans 32 markets and 17 sectors, with companies grouped according to government-defined revenue thresholds, found Indian businesses with AI-ready data report broad or strong returns on investment (ROI) at 6.3 times the rate of businesses whose data is only partially ready. This underscores the strong relationship between data readiness and returns from AI.

Julian Prower, Dun & Bradstreet's managing director and CEO for India and Taiwan.

"While optimism around AI adoption remains high, businesses still need to address several readiness gaps, particularly in terms of infrastructure, skills and operational capabilities, before they can fully realize its potential," said Arun Singh, chief economist at the firm. The survey found that only 3% of Indian businesses describe their enterprise data as fully ready to support AI at scale, compared with 8% globally, highlighting a 5-percentage-point gap.

A further 44% of Indian businesses describe their data as partially ready. For companies seeking to scale AI and generate consistent returns, closing this data-readiness gap will be essential as investment and implementation accelerate.

Nearly 70% of Indian businesses expect to increase AI spending over the next 12 months and believe the technology will drive new products, services, business models and operational improvements in the coming quarter, Singh said. More than 60% of Indian businesses have moved beyond the planning and pilot stages of AI adoption, with 35% scaling pilots into production and 26% embedding AI across core processes. But only 25% report strong workforce readiness, while half say their employees have mixed capabilities. This indicates a gap between access to AI technology and the skills needed to use it effectively.

Nearly 7 in 10 Indian businesses plan to raise AI spending over the next 12 months, the AI Momentum survey showed

The executives said it was equally important to ensure that appropriate controls were in place, either internally or in collaboration with service providers, particularly on cybersecurity.

"We have an AI council that reviews all our initiatives, recognizing the importance of oversight and accountability," Prower said.

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After the Nasdaq 100 Index tumbled 6.4% on Thursday, stocks in Japan, Korea and Taiwan got swept along the following day. AP

AI market rout has investors scouring EMs for bargains

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Stock pickers seeking relief from the artificial intelligence (AI)-fuelled turbulence in global equities are zeroing in on opportunities in emerging markets (EMs).

The growing angst over AI has hit the main MSCI developing country index hard, because chip giants SK Hynix, Samsung Electronics and Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co. (TSMC) together account for almost 30% of the gauge. Those stocks dragged the benchmark to a seven-month low on Friday before recovering.

But looking beyond the AI trade, money managers say they're seeing a chance to profit from rock-bottom valuations and high dividend yields in emerging markets, which by one metric are the cheapest since the global financial crisis 18 years ago.

Money managers say they're seeing a chance to profit from rock-bottom valuations and high dividend yields in EMs

"Just hogging three or four names and being really concentrated actually doesn't work over the long term," said Sat Duhra, a portfolio manager at Janus Henderson Investors. "There's a whole bunch of other areas outside of AI that have worked really well, and that's where we positioned."

Duhra said Friday that he's been adding higher-yielding stocks in China and Hong Kong, citing "improving payout discipline." Although Hong Kong is classified as a developed market, a large share of companies listed there are domiciled in China. "We are not yet tempted to rebuild exposure to tech," he said.

Other investors highlight South American utilities, Chinese and Taiwanese consumer-goods manufacturers, and eastern and central European financial firms as compelling alternatives to AI-exposed stocks.

The turmoil that hit equities last week, as fears grew that the Democrats' sweep of US midterm elections could imperil the vast data centre buildout underpinning artificial intelligence, left few markets untouched.

After the Nasdaq 100 Index tumbled 6.4% on Thursday, stocks in Japan, Korea and Taiwan got swept along the following day. South Korea's tech-heavy benchmark, which rallied in the first half as momentum-chasing retail investors piled in, sank to the lowest since March. Even Swiss stocks, notable for their limited exposure to AI, at one point fell the most in eight months.

ASK's SageOne acquisition: what's in it for both asset managers?

Srushti Vaidya
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MUMBAI

EXPLAINER

ASK Investment Managers' acquisition of Pune-based SageOne Investment Managers brings together two fund houses with contrasting fortunes: SageOne has built scale in alternatives, while ASK is looking to revive investment performance. The deal raises a key question: why sell a business that has already scaled up?

Founded over a decade ago, SageOne manages around ₹9,000 crore in alternative assets. Scale is rare in this segment: just 99 of India's 538 portfolio managers had assets exceeding ₹1,000 crore as of September, according to Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) data.

ASK IM agreed to acquire SageOne IM in September. Founder Samit Vartak will become chief investment officer of the combined entity. He is swapping his SageOne equity for a stake in ASK IM, locked in for five years, rather than exiting entirely. He will also reinvest 80% of any cash consideration in the combined business, a person with direct knowledge of the matter told *Mint*. ASK IM, part of the ASK Group, manages ₹13,500 crore across its portfolio management services (PMS) and alternative investment funds (AIFs). Vartak will oversee the combined portfolio, taking its assets to nearly ₹22,500 crore.

What's in it for SageOne?

Distributors typically favour established brands in the alternative investment space, where the sheer number of options makes it difficult for newer fund managers to attract attention. An in-house distribution network can improve visibility and help smaller firms scale.

SageOne will gain access to ASK's distribution network, to expand its reach, said Srikanth Meenakshi, co-founder of PrimeInvestor. ASK has a sizeable base of offshore clients looking to invest in India, offering SageOne another potential source of investors, he added.

SageOne to be independent brand under ASK Group. ISTOCK

The deal also addresses one of the biggest risks in money management: dependence on a key individual. Vartak is the face of SageOne, making the firm's continuity closely tied to its founder.

"For a smaller investment firm, dependence on a few key individuals can pose a risk to its long-term continuity. Building a lasting institution requires us to retain our best people, attract exceptional talent and give the team a meaningful opportunity to create wealth," Vartak told *Mint*.

But the risk can persist even within a larger organization, said a Pune-based boutique fund manager. "If Samit Vartak was to leave ASK, investors would still face the risk of losing the person responsible for making key decisions," he said.

The transaction also gives Vartak an opportunity to build on SageOne's track record within a larger institutional platform. By retaining an equity stake in ASK, he can participate in the growth of India's asset management industry, where listed players command strong valuations. ICICI Prudential AMC traded at a P/E multiple of 47.8 times when it listed on 19 December 2025, while SBI Funds Management was trading at 38.06 times when it listed on 21 July.

ASK-SageOne tie-up takes the combined assets to ₹22,500 crore, with wider distribution and offshore reach

How will the deal work?

SageOne will operate as an independent brand within the ASK Group, focusing on alternative investments, while ASK concentrates on its upcoming mutual fund business, according to the person cited earlier. Vartak will continue managing the combined assets from Pune. "ASK's 16 existing schemes will be consolidated into a few, with investors given the option to move the money to SageOne schemes. Fresh inflows will also go into SageOne products," the person added.

The shift has raised concerns among some wealth managers associated with SageOne about whether its investment philosophy will remain unchanged.

"Given that our investors are invested in SageOne schemes, it was important to us that the key decision-making around portfolio selection remains independent, as it has been historically. Following our clarification with the SageOne team we understand that there is no change in the investment process and strategy management," said Vaibhav Porwal, co-founder at Dezerv.

ASK didn't respond to *Mint's* queries on the strategy after the acquisition till press time.

Why ASK needs SageOne

For ASK, Vartak's appointment could help address persistent performance challenges in its PMS business. ASK Asset Managers' PMS business has lost around 75% of assets, or over ₹22,000 crore, and around 14,000 clients over five years. As of October, it managed ₹7,686 crore across 6,124 clients, according to Sebi data. This PMS AUM is part of ASK's total ₹13,500 crore, with the balance held in AIFs. Weak performance is a key reason for the outflows. ASK's largest scheme, ASK Entrepreneurship Portfolio, underperformed its benchmark over the one-, three- and five-year periods as of September. Only one of its 16 schemes beat benchmarks over certain periods.

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Agrawal buys Lodha Worli office space for ₹163 cr

Madhurima Nandy
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Investor Mukul Agrawal has bought 20,000 square feet of office space for ₹163.08 crore in an under-construction commercial project by Lodha Developers in Mumbai's upscale Worli neighbourhood, underscoring demand for premium office spaces among business owners and investors.

The space occupies the entire 46th floor of the 60-storey Lodha Promina tower. Agrawal bought two office units on the floor through separate transactions, with the spaces to be combined for use. The transactions were registered on 6 November, according to documents from the Department of Registration and Stamps, Maharashtra. The purchases were made in the names of Param Capital and Param Capital Research.

Founded in 1993, Param is a capital market investment and trading firm that practises long-term, value investing across private and public markets. "At the highest end of the commercial real estate market, buyers are investing in an address that reflects their business stature, ambitions and long-term vision. They also look for seamless connectivity to key business districts such as Bandra-Kurla Complex and Nariman Point, along with easy access to the airport," said Fatima Saidi, head-luxury sales at property advisory Anarock Property Consultants.

A Lodha spokesperson did not respond to *Mint's* queries. Agrawal could not be reached immediately.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Beauty startups step out of e-commerce to widen reach

Digital-first brands Honasa, Nykaa and Plum are expanding offline to woo more consumers

Sowmya Ramasubramanian
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Digital-first beauty brands are deepening their presence in India's physical retail market as they look beyond e-commerce to reach consumers who still buy products from the neighbourhood store.

The shift is visible in the sales and distribution numbers of new-age companies such as Honasa Consumer, Nykaa and Plum Goodness. For these brands, offline retail offers a way to broaden their consumer base and help product discovery.

"Ultimately, if you want to reach new customers, they still need to be able to buy the product from general trade, modern trade or a nearby store. That is what is happening with a lot of digital brands," Meena said.

Online channels account for only around 20-25% of India's fast-growing beauty and personal care (BPC) sales, while quick commerce contributes an estimated 3-5%, according to Satish Meena, analyst at Datum Intelligence.

The rest of the market is largely served through various formats of offline retail, highlighting the opportunity for digital-first brands to expand beyond online channels.

India's BPC market was valued at $23 billion in fiscal year 2025 (FY25) and is expected to reach $40 billion by 2030, growing at a 12% CAGR, according to estimates by Redseer Strategy Consultants.

Honasa, which owns Mamaearth, The Derma Co and Aqualogica, reported over 40% on-year rise in general-trade secondary sales in the September quarter. Modern-trade offtake also grew over 40%, while average secondary sales per retailer rose over 30%. Its store count is around 320,000 retail outlets.

Online channels account for 20-25% of India's beauty and personal care sales, while quick commerce contributes around 3-5%. MINT

Nykaa is also gaining ground in physical retail, with its beauty business posting like-for-like growth of over 20% in the quarter, its strongest in six quarters. It added 14 outlets, taking its network to 338 across 111 cities. Its B2B arm, Superstore, also expanded its retailer base by 27% to over 500,000, the firm said in a stock-exchange filing.

For Plum Goodness, which started online in 2014 and entered offline retail in 2017, physical channels account for 25-30% of revenue. with the share remaining broadly stable over the past few years even as it expanded both online and offline, said Shankar Prasad, founder and chief executive.

Plum is present in around 50,000 general-trade outlets and 8,000-9,000 modern-trade outlets. General trade, including cosmetics shops, neighbourhood stores, chemists and supermarkets, contributes the bulk of its offline business. "We have 40,000-50,000 outlets now, and the universe that can take our kind of product is in the few lakhs. So there is a lot of headroom for us to grow within general trade."

Retailer acceptance has been driven by changing consumer preferences, including growing demand for premium products, greater transparency and wider choice, Prasad said. "The neighbourhood retailers understand their consumers very well", and have responded to these shifts by creating shelf space for newer brands, he added.

To support offline sales, Plum largely relies on digital media to build consumer awareness, supplemented by local activations. It is also sharpening its focus on geography and customer segmentation, mapping its marketing efforts to areas where it has distribution and the ability to serve demand.

"We have to be a little more considerate about where and to whom the brand advertises offline, compared with e-commerce, where campaigns can reach consumers across a much wider geography," Prasad said.

The opportunity is not uniform. Datum's Meena expects tier-2 cities and smaller markets to offer stronger traction for digital-first beauty brands in general and modern trade. In larger cities, consumers familiar with a brand may prefer to reorder online, leaving physical stores to play a greater role in discovery and trial.

"In tier-1 cities, e-commerce is taking that load. If you know the brand, you will end up purchasing online," he said. "Tier-2 and beyond is where you will see more traction."

Meanwhile, the expansion is coinciding with improved profitability at both Honasa and Nykaa, though neither company has attributed the gains to offline growth alone. Honasa's Ebitda margin rose to 12.7% in the September quarter from 8.9% a year earlier. Nykaa's consolidated Ebitda margin increased to 8.7% from from 6.8% a year earlier. Both companies cited a combination of channel mix, operating leverage and other cost efficiencies.

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SHELF AMBITIONS

INDIA'S BPC market was $23 billion in FY25 and is set to grow at a 12% CAGR to $40 billion by 2030

HONASA'S average secondary sales per retailer rose 30%; its network spans 320,000 outlets

NYKAA'S beauty retail arm posted like-for-like growth of 20%, its strongest in six quarters

OFFLINE accounts for 25-30% of Plum's revenue, with a presence in 58,000-59,000 retail outlets

Forevermark sets ₹1,000 cr revenue target for India biz

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Mallikarjuna Reddy Yarabolu, MD, Forevermark. MINT

Forevermark, the natural diamond jewellery brand owned by the De Beers Group, is targeting 100 stores and revenue of $100 million (₹1,000 crore) in India over five years, betting on growing demand in the country.

The expansion marks a shift for the company, which previously supplied diamonds through partner jewellers and now seeks greater control over product design, pricing and consumer experience.

The company opened its first store in September 2025 in Delhi and has since added 11 outlets in the country. It expects to operate about 15 stores before the fiscal year ends, Mallikarjuna Reddy Yarabolu, managing director, Forevermark, De Beers India, said.

It plans outlets in 20 cities—eight metros and extended metropolitan markets and 12 other cities, including Patna and Mangaluru, where it is already present, besides Guwahati, Chandigarh and Ranchi, he said. The company intends to operate one-third of its stores. Of its first 10 outlets, six are company-operated and four franchised. Of the 100 stores, it expects 25-30 owned outlets, while the rest will be run by franchise partners. Each of the owned and operated stores costs about ₹10 crore to set up.

It plans 100 stores across 20 cities, with 25-30 owned outlets; the rest will be operated by franchise partners

"Jewellery retail requires a meaningful investment, so it has to be an equal partnership. We don't want a model where only the firm makes money." Yarabolu said the business was close to breaking even.

De Beers Group, which is 85% owned by London-based Anglo American, with the government of Botswana holding 15%, is a global diamond firm with operations spanning exploration, mining, sorting and trading rough diamonds.

It also sells polished diamonds and jewellery through consumer brands including De Beers London and Forevermark, which is focused on India. De Beers says fewer than 1% of the world's diamonds qualify for its inscription, that is intended to signal the stone's provenance and quality standards.

India's retail diamond jewellery market is set to reach ₹68,600 crore by 2029, expanding at a compound annual rate of 2.7% from 2024, according to IMARC Group data cited in a CareEdge Research report. The retailer competes with jewellers such as Tanishq, Kalyan Jewellers, Malabar Gold & Diamonds, CaratLane, BlueStone and Orra across bridal, premium and everyday-wear categories.

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GMR's Bhogapuram airport UDF proposal upsets IndiGo

The move could increase costs for passengers and make air travel less affordable

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NEW DELHI

GMR Airports Ltd (India) has proposed nearly doubling user development fees (UDF) at the new Bhogapuram airport, near Visakhapatnam, in Andhra Pradesh over five years, while introducing distance-based charges for domestic passengers—a move experts say could make air travel more expensive and hurt passenger demand.

Under the proposal, domestic passengers would pay different fees depending on whether they are travelling up to 1,000km or beyond that distance. If approved, it would be India's first distance-based UDF structure. GMR says the proposed charges are necessary to recover its investment and financing costs, according to several communications reviewed by *Mint*.

The move could increase costs for passengers and make air travel less affordable, particularly in a price-sensitive market such as India, according to experts. They also questioned whether passengers should bear the burden of recovering large airport infrastructure investments.

The distance-based UDF proposal is unfair for passengers, said G.S. Bawa, secretary general of the Air Travellers Association. "Passengers are already burdened by high airfares. Such proposals make flying less attractive. If allowed, private airports will soon start determining UDF based on body weight."

The plan is before the Airports Economic Regulatory Authority of India (AERA), which sets airport charges at major airports. UDF is included in ticket prices and collected by airlines on behalf of airport operators.

GMR Visakhapatnam International Airport Ltd (GVIAL), a subsidiary of GMR Airports, has proposed two domestic passenger categories for the first control period, FY27 to FY31: journeys of up to 1,000km and those beyond 1,000km.

In FY27, departing passengers would pay ₹1,000 on shorter routes and ₹1,230 on longer ones. For arriving passengers, the proposed fees are ₹400 and ₹530, respectively. By FY31, departure fees would rise to ₹2,090 and ₹2,460, while arrival fees would increase to ₹890 and ₹1,050. This would mean the charges would more than double in some categories over five years.

International passengers would face a single slab. Their departure fee would rise from ₹1,720 in FY27 to ₹3,450 in FY31, while the arrival fee would increase from ₹750 to ₹1,500.

The proposal follows an interim order in which AERA set flat charges of ₹835 for domestic departures and ₹355 for arrivals. The proposed charges at Bhogapuram are significantly higher than those at other major airports.

For FY27, AERA set Navi Mumbai International Airport's domestic UDF at ₹620 for departures and ₹270 for arrivals. Bengaluru's revised UDF, effective September, is ₹300 for departures and ₹125 for arrivals. Mumbai charges ₹175 for departures and ₹75 for arrivals.

GMR says the proposed charges are necessary to recover its costs. MINT

BONE OF CONTENTION

USERS would pay different fees for journeys of up to 1,000km and longer distances

IF APPROVED, it would be the country's first distance-based UDF structure

INDIGO has also objected to the proposal, arguing that airport charges are already high

THE objection comes as IndiGo CEO Willie Walsh steps up his criticism of airport costs

IndiGo, the country's largest airline, has objected to the proposal, arguing that airport charges are already high and further increases would make flying less affordable. "We would request AERA not to consider the airport operator's proposal to have different UDF rates based on distance," it said in a 31 October submission to the regulator.

The airline said combined departure and arrival fees at Bhogapuram would be more than twice those at the old Visakhapatnam airport for domestic passengers, and more than three times for international passengers. "Higher airport charges tend to reduce demand, especially in the price-sensitive Indian market," Malhotra wrote.

The objection comes as IndiGo chief executive officer (CEO) Willie Walsh steps up his criticism of airport costs. "Airport charges are too high and so this market would do much better if we had lower taxes," he said on 2 November. He has also described airports as "effective monopolies."

In a 5 November response to AERA, GMR said the proposed fee structure was necessary to recover total revenue requirement (ARR), or the revenue it is allowed to earn through regulated charges. "The proposed UDF structure has been designed to ensure recovery of the approved ARR over the First Control Period," it said. The company added that any reduction in UDF would require adjustments to other airport charges.

The stakes are high. The first phase of Bhogapuram airport, built at a cost of ₹5,640 crore according to the Centre's announcement before its opening, is designed to handle six million passengers a year. This is double the three million passengers handled by the old Visakhapatnam airport in FY26, around 4% of whom were international.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Remake strategy is evolving, and Bollywood must take note

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Drishyam 3 takes a different route from its Malayalam original to draw audiences.

While the age-old strategy of remaking films from Hollywood and regional Indian languages has not been abandoned, Hindi cinema increasingly has to adapt to the fact that most originals are now available on streaming platforms, often with subtitles and dubbed versions. As a result, entertainment industry experts say remakes must build on proven intellectual property (IP) while offering a fresh theatrical perspective.

The recent release *Drishyam: The Conclusion* illustrates this shift. Its plot is significantly different from that of the Malayalam original, a departure that appears to have worked in its favour. The thriller had earned over ₹370 crore at last count. In contrast, several Bollywood releases, including *Vikram Vedha*, *Jersey*, *Shehzada* and *Selfiee*, struggled when their southern originals were readily available online.

"The new rule increasingly has to be: 'Adapt the IP, don't photocopy the film.'" Audiences can now watch originals instantly on OTT or in dubbed versions, so a frame-for-frame remake has very little discovery value. *Drishyam 3* takes this to the extreme: unlike the first two Hindi films, it uses a completely different story from the Malayalam third instalment," said Rohit Dalmia, chairman and managing director, CineNow, an entertainment financing platform.

Remakes must build on proven intellectual property while offering a fresh theatrical perspective

The strategy seems to be working. The thriller opened bigger than any of the previous instalments, collecting ₹62 crore on its first day.

"The performance (of *Drishyam 3*) is a strong indicator of the trust audiences place in an established franchise and the anticipation that familiar, content-led stories can build around a theatrical release. When a franchise has earned that trust, the theatre remains the destination audiences choose to experience its next chapter, particularly during high-intent viewing periods," Ashish Saksena, chief operating officer-Cinemas, BookMyShow, had said in a statement post the release of the film. He had added that in just five days, the film had reached 75% of *Drishyam 2*'s lifetime ticket sales, with advance bookings four times and opening-day sales three times higher than its predecessor.

To be sure, in the initial years after the pandemic, southern film remakes in Hindi, once a reliable recipe for box-office success, began losing their appeal amid a series of failures. Trade experts pointed to the growing popularity of original southern films on streaming services, many of which also offered Hindi-dubbed versions, as a factor behind the decline in demand for remake rights.

Over time, however, a new opportunity has emerged: acquire proven IP but create a fresh theatrical experience. *Drishyam 2* had already added characters and altered the pacing because the Malayalam version had been widely watched on OTT. It ultimately became a major Hindi hit.

The challenge, trade experts say, is finding the right balance. Change too little and audiences feel they have already seen the film; change too much and producers risk losing the very appeal that made the remake rights valuable in the first place.

In fact, Dalmia said future deals may place greater value on the IP framework rather than the exact screenplay. The upcoming Hollywood adaptation of Vijay Sethupathi's Tamil thriller Maharaja is another example, where the core premise will inevitably have to be culturally reinterpreted rather than simply reproduced.

Film producer, trade and exhibition expert Girish Johar said there has been a conscious and evident shift in how remakes are being approached since the pandemic.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Trilateral talks being held between Russia and Ukraine mediated by the US in Abu Dhabi on Tuesday AP/PTI

US-led peace talks with Russia and Ukraine begin

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A new round of talks to end the war in Ukraine kicked off on Tuesday as US President Donald Trump's administration seeks to restart the peace process even as Russia shows no sign it's willing to compromise.

The talks involving Russian and Ukrainian officials got under way in Abu Dhabi, with Trump's negotiators, special envoy Steve Witkoff and the president's son-in-law Jared Kushner leading US mediation efforts.

Representatives of the UK, France, Germany, Italy, North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) and the European Commission met with the Ukrainian delegation earlier on Tuesday to align positions ahead of the discussions, Rustem Umerov, who heads the Ukrainian delegation, said in a post on X social media platform. They were joined by Witkoff and Kushner, he said.

"Our key priorities are to end hostilities, secure reliable post-war security guarantees, ensure Ukraine's economic recovery and development, and advance humanitarian efforts," Umerov said in the post. "We are working to make as much progress as possible on these issues and bring peace closer."

Moscow has stepped up missile and drone attacks on Ukrainian energy infrastructure ahead of winter

Russia hopes the meeting will "allow us to move forward on the path to peace," Vladimir Medinsky, the head of Russia's delegation, said in televised comments at the start of the talks.

The discussions scheduled to take place over two days mark a resumption of talks put on hold in February when the Trump administration's focus shifted to the Iran war. And they represent the first round of negotiations on Ukraine since Trump's Republican Party lost control of Congress in US midterm elections.

The Russian and Ukrainian envoys will discuss territorial issues and proposals for ceasefire monitoring in the United Arab Emirates, a senior US official said Monday.

The first session would focus on ceasefire monitoring and post-war security, including mechanisms for security consultations, crisis communications and de-escalation measures. A second session would touch on territorial issues, with the official saying that both sides had shown flexibility in recent days, without providing details.

The diplomatic push comes with little sign of de-escalation with Russia's full-scale invasion deep into its fifth year. Moscow has stepped up missile and drone attacks on Ukrainian energy infrastructure ahead of winter, while fighting continues along the frontline and Kyiv regularly strikes targets deep inside Russia as a way of curbing the Kremlin's war revenue.

The US official, who briefed reporters on condition of anonymity Monday, said there had been daily discussions with both Russia and Ukraine in the run-up to the trilateral meeting and expressed cautious optimism representatives would make progress.

The official said the US team had asked Russia for its consent for the US and Europe to provide security guarantees for Ukraine similar to those provided under Articles 4 and 5 of the NATO treaty, in which an attack on any member country is treated as an attack on the alliance as a whole. Ukraine is not a member of the NATO.

Trump's resumed efforts to end the war have reignited worries in Kyiv and allied capitals that the US will try to force territorial concessions or changes to Europe's security architecture. Trump told reporters last week, after meeting Putin envoy Kirill Dmitriev, that there could be a "big agreement" that is "going to involve more than Ukraine" and "might involve all of Europe," without elaborating.

Despite the new diplomacy, Russian President Vladimir Putin has publicly stuck to long-standing demands for Ukraine to surrender broad swaths of territory and to rule out ever joining NATO—demands rejected by Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy.

Anthropic targets $90 bn in IPO and placement with Big Tech

The Claude chatbot maker is seeking as much as $64.4 billion in its initial public offering for $70 to $78 each

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Anthropic chief executive Dario Amodei. The firm plans to make history as the first frontier AI lab to go public. REUTERS

Anthropic PBC and some of its shareholders are seeking to raise as much as $90.4 billion in an IPO and private placement, in a bid to make history as the first frontier artificial intelligence lab to go public and exceed the size of SpaceX's record-setting first-time share sale.

The Claude chatbot maker is seeking as much as $64.4 billion in its initial public offering for $70 to $78 each, according to a filing on Tuesday with the US Securities and Exchange Commission. Anthropic is offering 801.4 million shares, while backers are selling 23.6 million shares.

The offering also includes a private placement set to raise $26 billion in aggregate, to Advanced Micro Devices Inc., Broadcom Inc., Alphabet Inc.'s Google, Micron Technology Inc., Microsoft Corp., Nvidia Corp. and Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Co., the filing shows.

At the top of the price range, Anthropic would have a market value of about $1 trillion, based on the shares outstanding listed in the filing.

Anthropic's ambitious target, including the private placement, would top SpaceX's $75 billion base offering, or the $86.2 billion it raised with an over-allotment option. The goal defies jitters from a sharp selloff in AI-related stocks last week, driven by expectations that politicians promising tougher regulation of data centers and related infrastructure will drive up costs and limit development of the technology.

Investors are under pressure to decide whether valuations in AI reflect a plausible trajectory for a technology that many expect to transform the economy and society as a whole, or overconfidence in an investment theme that hasn't yet proven its staying power.

The widespread adoption of Claude Code and rival tools by software developers point to the potential transformation of a wide range of professional activity, from discovering new miracle drugs to navigating complex legal and accounting rules to running a factory. Already, more than 90% of contributions to Anthropic's code base were written by Claude, the filing shows.

Anthropic has introduced so-called vertical solutions in these areas, with particular emphasis on healthcare and life sciences. It counts Novartis AG Chief Executive Officer Vas Narasimhan as one of its board members.

Sales are surging. The company reported third-quarter revenue of nearly $17 billion as of Sept. 30, versus $1.4 billion in the same period a year ago, its filing shows. On Monday Anthropic unveiled new versions of its powerful Mythos and Fable models, both of which are faster than prior versions, while Fable is less expensive, as some companies cut back on their spending on the technology.

Anthropic's ambitious target, including private placement, would top SpaceX's $75 billion base offering

Keeping the pace of development running at a breakneck pace will require growing revenue faster than Anthropic's spending on AI infrastructure. Anthropic has $895 billion of commitments, most of which are for computing power, chips, the filing shows. About $70 billion worth — a figure that's larger than the individual market caps of roughly two thirds of S&P 500 companies — are due just in the year through September 2027.

Unlike other tech companies with sources of income such as advertising to fall back on, Anthropic will have to convince investors that its focus on AI alone will generate profit far beyond the technology's surging costs.

That hasn't stopped asset managers, venture capital firms and some of the biggest tech companies from backing Anthropic to the tune of tens of billions of dollars. Funds scattered across investment houses including Fidelity Investments, Capital Group and BlackRock Inc. and VCs such as Iconiq, Spark Capital and Sequoia Capital hold Anthropic shares before the IPO. Alphabet Inc.'s Google, Amazon.com Inc. and Microsoft Corp. are backers as well as customers and key suppliers of computing power.

The speed of development has become increasingly controversial, with Anthropic's own Chief Executive Officer Dario Amodei among those calling for top AI labs to "pace the frontier" in order to prioritize safety. Anthropic itself warned that the technology could pose "catastrophic or existential risks to humanity" in its IPO filing, if the technology isn't developed with adequate safeguards and oversight.

Regulators, investors and even Anthropic's employees have flagged the significant risk of humans losing control of the technology, with one putting the chance of AI eliminating all humans in the next decade at greater than 10%. Bill Gates said AI is powerful enough to drive events that cause "a billion deaths."

Anthropic's rival OpenAI is targeting a 2027 listing and Chief Executive Officer Sam Altman called 2026 an "ill-advised moment" for an IPO, citing concern over AI safety. The company is raising funds at a $1.25 trillion valuation, people familiar with the matter have said.

Anthropic's origin story centers around former OpenAI executives defecting because they wanted to prioritize AI safety. Nearly six years after its founding, Anthropic has structured itself as a public benefit corporation that balances shareholder interests with that of society, and whose governance includes a Long-Term Benefit Trust that has the power to elect and remove a majority of the members of the company's board.

Anthropic's seven co-founders hold roughly 1.4% stakes in the company, making them each billionaires several times over. That remains true even if they stick to their pledges to give 80% of their personal equity in the company to philanthropic causes.

The company's total operating expenses jumped to $17.5 billion in the third quarter, a 292% increase from a year prior. It flipped from an operating profit of $974 million in the second quarter — its first after at least five quarters of operating losses — back to a negative $567 million in the three months ended Sept. 30, according to the filing.

The operating loss in the third quarter was primarily driven by $5 billion of computing costs under short-term commitments and $2 billion of non-cash charges related to the company's charitable donation-matching program.

AI pricing pressures have begun to hit Anthropic's revenue. Lower prices on some of its new models, plus contractual discounts for some customers, reduced its revenue growth in the third quarter by about $600 million, the filing shows.

Anthropic has cut prices in newer model rollouts, including Opus 5.5 in September, and OpenAI has also introduced lower-priced models in recent months. The AI giants face growing competition from cheaper open-weight models, including from Chinese developers, which customers can download and fine-tune to their needs.

Goldman Sachs Group Inc. and Morgan Stanley are leading Anthropic's IPO, with participation from 20 other banks, the filing shows.

Hedge fund founder Shah fights 12-year Danish jail sentence

Bloomberg
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British hedge fund trader Sanjay Shah returned to court in Denmark to try to overturn a 12-year prison sentence for orchestrating a billion-dollar tax scam.

The 56-year-old Solo Capital founder, who in late 2024 was handed the heaviest jail term so far in Europe's sprawling Cum-Ex trading scandal, appeared before the High Court in Copenhagen on Tuesday to begin an appeal seeking acquittal.

A lower court convicted Shah of serious fraud for creating a scheme that defrauded the Nordic nation's treasury of more than 9 billion kroner ($1.35 billion) through thousands of sham dividend-tax refund applications between 2012 and 2015.

Shah has consistently maintained his innocence, claiming he merely took advantage of legal loopholes. He's also argued that he could never get a fair trial because Danish government ministers had labelled him guilty from the start.

Denmark was at the heart of what has been one of Europe's biggest tax scandals involving thousands of bankers, traders and lawyers, who exploited dividend payout laws across the region to reap duplicate tax refunds.

Solo Capital founder Sanjay Shah. WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

The Danish tax agency has also sued Shah and dozens of traders and businesses in a civil case in London, which it lost last year after the court found it had failed to prove deceit and criticized its controls for preventing wrongful tax refunds as close to non-existent.

The UK ruling will be a new element in Shah's defence, his lawyer, Kaare Pihlmann, told the Danish court on Tuesday. Some 23 court hearings have been scheduled in Shah's appeal, with a verdict expected in the spring of 2027.

Shah has been detained in Denmark since his extradition from Dubai in 2023 and remained behind bars after his conviction, with the district court finding that he posed a flight risk while the appeal was pending.

The trader played an "central and controlling role" in the crime, the district court judge ruled in late 2024. Shah "carefully planned" the scheme and implemented software to streamline and expand it. More than 80% of the money flowed into his pockets, the judge said at the time.

Shah has maintained his innocence, claiming he merely took advantage of legal loopholes

Shah was the third trader to be convicted in Denmark in relation to the scandal, which cost the nation a total of 12.7 billion kroner. In 2024, fellow British trader Anthony Mark Patterson was sentenced to eight years in prison after pleading guilty to helping Shah operate the hedge fund's trading strategy, while Guenther Klar, who was originally handed six years in prison, had his Danish sentence reduced to three and a half years in 2025.

China's trade surplus surged past $1 trillion in October

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China's trade surplus surged to more than $1 trillion in the first 10 months of the year as the country's factories cranked out electric vehicles, semiconductors and industrial robots for customers around the world.

The export wave puts China on track to exceed its record $1.19 trillion trade surplus last year and is likely to further stoke tensions with Beijing's trading partners.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Exports rose 35% from a year earlier in October, according to official data released Tuesday, slightly down from 36% growth the previous month. Shipments to Europe rose by nearly a quarter year-over-year and to the U.S. by a third. The total surplus for the first 10 months of the year reached $1.04 trillion.

China is highly reliant on exports for growth as it reckons with economic weakness at home. The country is confronting a brutal property crash, sluggish consumer spending and high youth unemployment. Struggling to make profits at home, many Chinese companies have rushed overseas to find customers.

China's trade surplus with the world is roughly triple the level in 2019. The surge in its industrial activity is such that the country could be making 45% of the world's goods by 2030, according to the United Nations Industrial Development Organization, compared with 6% in 2000.

The deluge of exports is raising alarm in many countries, particularly in Europe, where officials worry that Chinese competition is hollowing out local industries. The Group of 20 has criticized China's overreliance on exports, and the International Monetary Fund warned Beijing in a September report that exports "cannot remain a major engine of growth."

The European Union and Beijing agreed to cap shipments of Chinese hybrid vehicles in talks last month. President Trump and Chinese leader Xi Jinping will likely discuss trade issues at an expected meeting in Shenzhen next week during the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation conference. The two superpowers extended a tariff truce in September after a painful trade war last year.

"Everyone is, in a sense, facing the same damn problem," said Brad Setser, trade expert at the Council on Foreign Relations and former senior adviser to the U.S. trade representative.

Chinese exports continue to soar despite economic gloom and global trade tensions CHINA DAILY VIA REUTERS

Beijing has pushed back against critics who say the export machine is a result of China's lopsided economic model and government support for key industries, arguing that export gains are a result of innovation and global demand for Chinese products.

Chinese imports increased by more than 41% in October compared with a year earlier, according to the official data.

The artificial intelligence boom has boosted China's export machine, as prices for chips and other computing equipment have risen sharply alongside demand for AI. Exports of integrated circuits increased by 111% in value in the first 10 months of the year, as per data released Tuesday.

China has "successfully cornered the market" for many components necessary for high-tech products, said Christopher Millward, former president of the U.S. Information Technology Office, a trade association representing U.S. tech firms in China. "It's part of a broader effort to really make China the dominant manufacturing force on the planet—and it's been successful."

Exports rose 35% from a year earlier in October, slightly down from 36% growth the previous month

Electric-vehicle exports have also ballooned as Chinese giants like BYD conquer global markets.

Geely Automobile, one of China's largest EV makers, sold over 300,000 vehicles last month, with exports of its EVs surging over 500% year-over-year. The Hangzhou-based company announced last week it had sold one million units globally of its popular electric model, the Geely E2, averaging one car sold a minute over two years.

This export rise is unfolding as Chinese car companies grapple with fewer customers and intense price wars domestically. Through September, Chinese consumers have bought about 22% fewer passenger vehicles this year than in the same period in 2025.

Geely founder Li Shufu has warned against the bitter competition besetting local industry and pushing companies overseas. "We should not simply engage in price wars," Li said in March, according to Chinese state media, criticizing what he called "excessive internal competition."

It isn't just cars and high-tech goods. China now makes nearly half of the global capacity for basic chemicals and plastic resins, according to a Rhodium Group report released last week. Chinese capacity to produce several chemicals critical for manufacturing and agriculture have surged more than 75% from 2020 to 2025, the report found. Chemical exports from China are rising, especially to the developing world, as demand for chemicals softens at home.

State-owned Sinopec's chemical exports expanded by 70% year-over-year to reach a "historic high" in the first half of this year, according to a company release.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

$2.1 tn
THE TOTAL inflows US equity funds have attracted since 2020, which is 4.5 times the $470 billion drawn by Emerging Market Asia equity funds, per the Kobeissi Letter.

₹53,739 cr
THE AMOUNT foreign portfolio investors have invested in Indian equities so far in November, after sustained selling through most of 2026, per NSDL data.

$3 bn
THE INVESTMENT Honda Motor Co. plans for a new factory in Ohio to manufacture next-generation hybrids and boost its overall output capacity.

5%
THE PERCENTAGE of its commercial airplane workforce Boeing will cut, marking the planemaker's first job reduction in nearly two years.

850
THE NUMBER of head office jobs Qantas plans to outsource to Accenture under a multi-year agreement, with most of these roles shifting to India.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

JLR sees India as a key growth market

Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) sees India as a key growth market and plans to introduce its first electric vehicles here in 2027, including the Range Rover Electric and Range Rover Sport Electric, as the luxury automaker looks to tap emerging opportunities in the premium electric vehicle (EV) segment, its India managing director and chief executive officer Rajan Amba said.

In an interview to *PTI*, Amba shared that the company will also introduce the new Jaguar GT next year, with the product launches spread across different periods.

"Electric is the way forward," he said, adding that the timing was appropriate for the company to enter the Indian electric vehicle market.

JLR India, which does not have an electric vehicle in its portfolio, is encouraged by the growth witnessed in the EV market. **PTI**

MRF posts lower quarterly profit as higher costs bite

MRF reported a near 28% fall in second-quarter profit on Tuesday, as higher costs for raw materials overshadowed strong demand for its tyres.

The Wanderer-tyre maker's profit fell to ₹369 crore ($39.29 million) in the quarter ended 30 September, from ₹512 crore a year earlier.

Revenue from operations rose by almost 18% to ₹8,524 crore, while total expenses grew by more than 22%, driven largely by a rise in material costs related to war in the Middle East.

Cost of materials consumed grew by about 44% during the quarter. Demand for tyres remained resilient in the July-September quarter, supported by steady dispatches from automakers. **REUTERS**

Cochin Shipyard Q2 profit declines 50% to ₹53.8 crore

Cochin Shipyard Ltd on Tuesday reported a 50% decline in consolidated net profit to ₹53.77 crore in the quarter ended September.

The state-owned company had posted a consolidated net profit of ₹107.52 crore in the second quarter of the preceding financial year, according to a regulatory filing.

Total income in the September quarter of financial year 2026-27 increased to ₹1,331.81 crore from ₹1,245.88 crore in the year-ago period.

The public sector shipbuilding firm's total expenses rose to ₹1,256.71 crore in the September quarter from ₹1095.97 crore in the year-ago period.

The company's board also approved an interim dividend of ₹3 per equity share of ₹5 each, fully paid up (60%) for financial year 2026-27. **PTI**

Bajaj Finance issues 57.4 mn warrants

Non-banking financial company Bajaj Finance on Tuesday allotted 57.4 million warrants to promoter Bajaj Finserv on a preferential basis for ₹5,799 crore.

A special committee of the board of directors of the company has approved the issue of 57,425,740 warrants to the promoter, at an issue price of ₹1,010 per warrant, for an amount aggregating to ₹5,799.9 in accordance with Chapter V of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), Bajaj Finance said in a regulatory filing.

"Each of the warrants is convertible into an equivalent number of equity shares, which are pari-passu with the fully paid-up equity shares of the company," it said.

On issue, at least 25% of the consideration is payable on allotment, with the remaining 75% due when warrants are converted into equity shares, as per Sebi's Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements regulations. **PTI**

India flags rich countries' climate finance obligations

India reiterates its commitment to contributing its share to global action at COP31

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NEW DELHI

AP

India has stepped up pressure on developed nations to honour their climate finance commitments, saying poorer countries can't be expected to shoulder the rising costs of fighting climate change while meeting their own development needs. At the 31st Conference of the Parties (COP31) on the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC) in Antalya, Türkiye, India said equity, adaptation and a just energy transition must stay central to global climate negotiations, particularly for developing economies.

Delivering India's opening statement, Narendra Bhooshan, secretary at the environment ministry, said developed countries had an obligation under the Paris Agreement to provide financial resources to support climate action in the developing nations.

India called for greater financial support for developing economies, particularly to help them adapt to rising climate risks and make a fair transition to cleaner energy. The appeal comes amid mounting concerns over global warming breaching the 1.5°C threshold.

Bhooshan reaffirmed India's commitment to climate multilateralism and the principle of Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC).

India stressed that Article 9.1 of the Paris Agreement places an obligation on developed countries to provide financial resources to developing nations to support climate action. "Public finance from developed countries remains central to catalysing climate action in developing countries and strengthening adaptation finance flows to address their vulnerabilities," the government's press statement said.

India also reiterated its commitment to contributing its fair share to global climate action while pursuing the development and wellbeing of its people. It said a just transition and meeting adaptation needs remain significant challenges, particularly for the Global South, where these are closely intertwined with the challenge of development itself. India also welcomed the COP31 presidency's vision of a 'COP of Implementation', centred on dialogue, consensus and action, and said the UNFCCC and the Paris Agreement remain the most inclusive platforms for global climate cooperation.

NMDC officials visited Russia last month and held talks with Rosatom. BLOOMBERG

NMDC, Rosatom in lithium project talks

Indian state-run miner NMDC Ltd is in talks with Russia's Rosatom to invest in Russian lithium projects, three people familiar with the matter said, as India steps up efforts to secure supplies of the metal for its battery and EV industries.

NMDC officials visited Russia last month for a conference and also held talks with state nuclear firm Rosatom, two of the people said.

The third person, who also confirmed that company officials had met with Rosatom, said NMDC was keen to explore lithium mining and processing opportunities in Russia and had also held discussions with other Russian companies. All three people, who asked not to be named as the talks were confidential, said discussions between NMDC and Rosatom remain preliminary. A Rosatom spokesperson did not address Reuters queries about the meetings last month but said the Russian company was not currently engaged in talks with NMDC. NMDC said last year it was exploring acquisition opportunities for critical minerals in Africa, Australia and South America as part of its global mineral diversification strategy. **REUTERS**

Adani Group has been expanding aggressively across infrastructure and energy. AP

Adani Group plans $120 billion capex

Adani Group plans to invest more than $120 billion in capital expenditure over the next five years across its core infrastructure businesses and emerging growth platforms, its executives told Fortune India in an interview on Tuesday.

Adani Group, one of India's largest conglomerates, has been expanding aggressively across infrastructure and energy, with investments spanning ports, airports, power, renewables and other sectors.

"Over the next five years, we plan to invest about $120 billion, over $20 billion a year, across all our businesses," Pranav Adani, a director at the group's flagship firm Adani Enterprises and the nephew of group chairman Gautam Adani, told *Fortune India*.

Broadly, about 70% of these investments will be in energy, about 20% in transport and logistics and 10% in business adjacencies such as cement, copper, and aluminium, the report said. The investments are expected to double the group's asset base to $191.64 billion and generate ₹2.6-3 trillion in core earnings within five years. **REUTERS**

Latin America lures India's two-wheelers

FROM PAGE 1

ket," CEO Harshavardhan Chitale said at the 29 October earnings call. "So that's a big market we're expanding in. We are also increasing our presence in Mexico. Both are large Latin American markets for two-wheelers."

Hero's board has cleared an additional investment of up to ₹300 crore in its wholly-owned Netherlands subsidiary that will route funds to its Colombia and Brazil arms.

Hero's Colombia subsidiary saw a turnover of ₹1,656 crore in FY26, up from ₹672 crore a year earlier, while its Brazil one is yet to commence business, according to the filing.

Colombia accounts for close to a quarter of Hero's exports, with Bangladesh contributing a similarly high share, leaving the company exposed when both markets faced disruptions in July-September.

Bajaj Auto is looking to deepen its product offering beyond its traditional markets.

In its 27 October earnings call, joint managing director Rakesh Sharma said Bajaj plans to open a new segment in existing markets, particularly outside Africa, which could be a "surprise package". He also said Bajaj will add new markets in two to three years.

"In Latin America, including Brazil, the industry grew about 12%, while we grew 44%," Sharma said. Bajaj's exports in the 150cc and above sports segment in Latin America rose 50%, making it the leader in 150-250cc category.

Bajaj's Manaus plant, operational since 2024, has an annual capacity of 50,000 units, as per its FY26 annual report. Separately, Bajaj-owned Austrian bikemaker KTM opened a dedicated plant in Manaus in October, with an installed capacity of 20,000 motorcycles a year.

Bajaj indicated plans to enter new product segments in Latin America, while KTM opened a 20K-unit plant in Manaus, Brazil

The facility will assemble 10 KTM and Husqvarna models across motocross, enduro and adventure segments, with output likely to reach 3,500 units by the end of 2026.

TVS Motor has also flagged Latin America as a key export market. Its international two wheeler sales rose 33% in the September quarter, ahead of the industry's 27% growth.

"Africa continues to be a key driver, supported by other markets like LATAM, also Asia," chief executive K.N. Radhakrishnan said on the 28 October earnings call.

Royal Enfield is taking a more localized route in Brazil. In July, the company said it would set up its own completely knocked down (CKD) assembly facility in Manaus from 2027. The move builds on its existing assembly partnerships in Brazil, its largest overseas market.

Experts say that the push is underpinned by rising demand across Latin America, where motorcycles are being used as assets for delivery, courier and mototaxis.

"Across Latin America, growth is being driven by the motorcycle's shift from discretionary purchase to income generating asset, with delivery, mototaxi and courier work anchoring demand, aided by macro normalization through disinflation, rate easing and real income gains that have restored affordability. Deepening dealer point and in house financing has converted that affordability into volume," analyst at Kotak Institutional Equities wrote in a 15 September report.

Colombia has become the largest export market for Indian two-wheeler makers, accounting for 14-14.5% of overall exports in FY26 and the first quarter of FY27, the report said. India's two-wheeler exports grew 23% to 5.19 million units in FY26,

Hereon, Kotak sees growth easing to mid-single digits in Colombia and mid-to-high single digits in Brazil, while Mexico could grow at a low-single-digit pace this year.

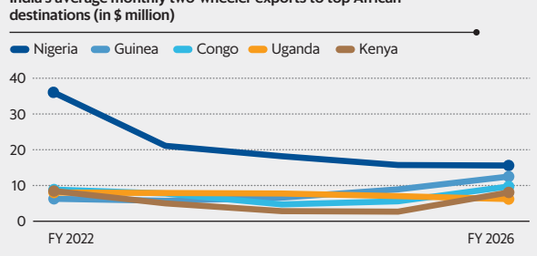
It expects Africa's two-wheeler market to grow at a high-single-digit pace, but says its electric segment could expand at 34.7% CAGR, driven by high usage and pricey fuel.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Regional shift

In Africa, an early wave of electric bikes led by firms like Spiro could leave petrol-bike makers behind.

India's average monthly two-wheeler exports to top African destinations (in $ million)



Source: Kotak Institutional Equities

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SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Midsize IT firms unveil new sales perks

FROM PAGE 1

riders. If they are selling one of our solutions, there are more riders on top of it. They can make huge amounts of money as well. It is (a) multiplier of what their bonus is. So, we want our sales team to be really, really rich...Very simple logic. You get a deal, you bring revenue to the company, you get a cut out of it," said Baruah.

Hexaware posted $412 million revenue in July-September, up 2% sequentially. It doesn't disclose order intake.

LTM is using incentives to push sales teams towards AI-native services, rather than relying on offerings they have traditionally sold.

"For AI native deals, for example, we have a different sales incentive for our salespeople because we want them to sell more of these deals," said Venu Lambu, chief executive of LTM at the earnings call on 16 October. "It is a change management exercise, right? There is a lot of comfort that you get to sell the same thing that you have been selling over the years. So hence, we are making an effort by incentivizing salespeople, to sell the new AI-native deals."

Different commission structures apply to different solutions. "There are different sales commission structures for the solutions that we sell in the new-age partners. And those are the things that, when you have a program driven like that, it gets reflected in the way you book your orders," he said.

LTM is using sops to push sales teams towards AI-native services, rather than relying on offerings they have traditionally sold. REUTERS

An email sent to LTM on Monday seeking more clarity on its commission structure went unanswered.

LTM ended the September quarter with revenue of $4.76 billion, rising 1% quarter-on-quarter. Order intake was at $1.26 billion, down 25%.

Hexaware Technologies has shifted its sales team from a quota-based to a commission-based model

Coforge is widening its approach to winning contracts. Traditionally reliant on sole-sourced deals rather than competitive bids, it has begun using external deal advisors and consultants to reach prospective clients. "The only thing I will add to that is that, in parallel to leveraging the solutions capability for proactive deals, we have also started of increasingly use some of the more advisory channels, and we are starting to see deals come in through those routes, which traditionally we have never had," said John Speight, president and executive director of Coforge at the earnings call on 23 October.

The company said advisory costs are accounted for under sales or other sales and marketing expenses, rather than traditional marketing budgets.

"Advisory costs will sit as part of either sales costs or other S&M (sales and marketing) costs. It is largely around that. It is not that the advisory cost is very, very significant, it's more about how they take us to clients, and how they recommend us to clients," said Saurabh Goel, CFO at Coforge, during the analyst call.

Coforge posted $652 million revenue for the September quarter, up 10% sequentially. Order intake rose 51% to $1.04 billion.

Larger peers, including Tata Consultancy Services Ltd and Infosys, said they were investing in their sales processes but did not elaborate.

The changes at mid-sized firms reflect the importance of sales talent in a market where winning new business is becoming more challenging.

"A more attractive commission structure allows these firms to attract better sales teams and also increases the motivation and performance. With growth such a premium and a moribund market, top sales talent is a premium," said Peter Bendor-Samuel, founder of Everest Group.

Namratha Dharshan, chief business leader for India Research at ISG, said the changes could also help firms retain key personnel. "Sales and business development is a high touch relationship-led engagement and retention of key account personnel matters significantly in driving these engagements," she said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

The spy scandal that lays bare Nvidia's governance vacuum

A chairman-less board and no named successor highlight how Nvidia's board does things CEO Jensen Huang's way

Theo Francis & Chip Cutter

Revelations that Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang had an affair with an executive suspected of spying for China are laying bare corporate governance practices nearly as extraordinary.

The $4.3 trillion chip giant lacks a chairman and a succession plan. It denied Huang's relationship only for him later to acknowledge it. And in announcing an investigation into the affair, its board publicly declared it had no reason to believe the company's secrets or national security were compromised even before the inquiry started.

"To say there's no issue before you've done an investigation, that's not appropriate," said Harry Kraemer Jr., the former CEO of Baxter International who now teaches management at Northwestern University's business school. "That's how you lose credibility."

Nvidia's idiosyncrasies received little investor attention as the chip maker's stock soared over the past five years. Now, they are fanning questions about the board's oversight—and whether it can steer Nvidia through a crisis with the potential to ripple across the AI economy.

On Sunday, Nvidia's board said it would investigate reports Huang was a foreign espionage target, even as it suggested it didn't expect to find serious problems. "The board has confidence in Jensen and his leadership team," it said in a statement.

Central to the scandal is a company dominated by a charismatic CEO and overseen by an unusual board that has changed little with Nvidia's meteoric rise.

Huang founded Nvidia 33 years ago, well before artificial intelligence fed red-hot demand for its chips and made it one of the most valuable U.S. companies.

Other high-profile tech founders wield control through big stock stakes or supervoting shares. Huang held just 3.6% of Nvidia's shares as of late March.

That's still a fortune topping $150 billion at recent prices, and Huang's profile is huge, at the company and beyond. Huang has drawn crowds and plaudits in his signature black leather jacket and is a close ally of President Trump.

On the company's most recent quarterly earnings call, Huang fielded questions from analysts largely solo, leaving scripted introductory remarks to others. That's typical for Nvidia but uncommon elsewhere. With no obvious No. 2, Huang has said he oversees more than 60 direct reports and runs Nvidia with a fairly flat organizational structure.

Nvidia founder and CEO Jensen Huang waves after a welcome ceremony for US President Donald Trump in Beijing on 14 May. Chip giant Nvidia's board said on 8 November it had opened a probe into Huang after he acknowledged an affair with a woman US officials say was working for Chinese intelligence. AFP

His pay mirrors the role he plays in the AI economy, ranking him well above typical CEOs in *The Wall Street Journal*'s annual survey. He has realized about $2.4 billion in pay over the past two decades, mostly in stock and exercised options, according to compensation-data firm Equilar. Most of that has been in stock and exercised options.

Nvidia's board, by contrast, is more staid. As of last spring, three of Nvidia's 10 independent directors had held their seats for 25 years or more; two others had served more than a decade.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

Across the biggest U.S. companies, average board tenure is under eight years, with just 10% serving for more than a decade, a recent analysis by executive search firm Heidrick & Struggles found.

Nvidia has no chairman. Only about 1% of publicly traded companies in the Russell 3000 share that trait, according to Equilar. Instead, Huang and the board's lead director, former Cooley CEO Stephen Neal, together draw up the agenda for board meetings, determine what information directors receive and preside over the meetings, Nvidia's securities filings indicate. Neal schedules board meetings and arranges quarterly executive sessions that Huang doesn't attend.

"When I see that, I say, 'OK, well, it's pretty clear that Jensen Huang is the chair,'" said Doug Chia, former corporate secretary of Johnson & Johnson and president of consulting firm Soundboard Governance.

Ideally, a chairman should serve as a strong figure to guide the board in overseeing management, including the CEO, said David Astorino, senior partner at leadership consulting firm RHR International.

Instead, with Nvidia's lead director, "it felt like those roles were very overlapping, very collaborative, very respectful and deferential to the founder," Astorino said. "A lot of founder-led companies of a certain size or scale have a similar dynamic."

A lead director can often be enough, some corporate governance experts say. In years past, boards might rarely or never have met without the CEO present. Lead directors also serve as a counterbalance to CEOs who simultaneously chair the board.

Nvidia's board has changed slowly, even with the company's increasing growth and geopolitical influence. Just two directors have joined in the past five years, company disclosures show: Melissa Lora, the former president of Taco Bell International, who joined in 2023, and former Goldman Sachs Vice Chairman Suzanne Nora Johnson, who joined this summer. Other directors include an engineering professor who advised President Joe Biden, the National Football League's former marketing chief, a former pharmaceutical-company executive and four professional investors.

"The level of scrutiny and professionalization required to run a company that has become the size of Nvidia from where they were six years ago—it's hard to imagine that the board has kept up with that growth," said Donald Schepker, a University of South Carolina management professor and research director at its Center for Executive Succession. "I can't imagine it hasn't put stress on the board."

Overall, Nvidia ranked at the risky end of corporate-governance scoring by proxy advisory firm Institutional Shareholder Services last spring. ISS recommended that investors support the company's director candidates but assigned its riskiest rating to Nvidia's board structure.

ISS cited the board's multiple long-tenured directors and its lack of a chairman or a mechanism to refresh the board, among other factors.

At the Journal's Board of Directors Council in Palm Beach on Monday, Nvidia's crisis consumed conversations among attendees, many of whom sit on public-company boards. Some questioned whether the board had been too quick to protect Huang or initially accept his assurances about the relationship, and said the saga highlighted the importance of succession planning regardless.

"The question every other company needs to be thinking about is, 'Are we always thinking about management depth, succession and risk management?'" said Tom Monahan, CEO of Heidrick & Struggles.

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The spy who loved me: a timeline

2023
Megaspeed is created as a spinoff of Chinese company 7Road Holdings. The company aims to build data centres in South-East Asia with Nvidia chips, then rent the cloud computing capacity to customers.

JUN 2024
Alice Huang and Jensen Huang are photographed together in Taipei, Taiwan, along with other industry executives at an afterparty during a tech conference.

LATE 2024
The Commerce Department opens an investigation into Megaspeed and potential chip diversion directly to China that could violate export-control rules.

MAY 2025
Jensen Huang is photographed again with Alice Huang in Taipei during a private dinner at an industry conference.

9 OCT 2025
The New York Times reports that federal investigators are looking into Megaspeed and potential exports of chips to China and the connections between Alice Huang and Jensen Huang.

28 OCT 2025
Jensen Huang praises President Trump's policies in a MAGA-themed speech at a Nvidia summit in Washington, D.C.

30 OCT 2025
Trump flies to Busan, South Korea, for a summit with Chinese leader Xi Jinping. In discussions, China hawks in the administration persuade Trump not to grant Jensen Huang's request to approve Nvidia Blackwell chips for sale in China.
THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

8 DEC 2025
Trump agrees to let Nvidia export a less powerful chip, the H200, directly to China in exchange for 25% of the sales going to the federal government.

SPRING 2026
Secretary of State Marco Rubio supervises the drafting of a classified memo warning that Huang had a personal relationship with Alice Huang, according to people familiar with the matter.

13 MAY
Jensen Huang is a last-minute addition to Trump's China trip, boards Air Force One in Alaska and joins other corporate executives.

14 SEP
Trump calls Jensen Huang during live taping of "All-In" podcast and the two men praise each other and the president's light-touch AI strategy.

8 OCT
Trump awards Jensen Huang and other executives the National Medal of Science.

29 OCT–1 NOV
Media outlets report that U.S. intelligence officials were concerned that Alice Huang was a Chinese intelligence asset last year and that she had a close relationship with Jensen Huang.

8 NOV
Nvidia board begins investigation into whether Jensen Huang shared secrets with Alice Huang.

Chinese businesswoman Alice Huang's journey from finance to chips

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
TAIPEI/SHANGHAI/BEIJING

Alice Huang built a career in Chinese finance before emerging in a very different arena: the global race for artificial-intelligence chips.

Known also as Huang Le, the Chinese businesswoman held senior roles at a Shanghai investment firm before becoming the controlling shareholder of Singapore-based cloud-computing company Megaspeed International, according to more than 30 publicly available financial records, corporate filings and company materials reviewed by Reuters.

Nvidia lists Megaspeed as an official cloud partner on its directory. Megaspeed attracted public attention in October 2025, when the New York Times reported the company was under US investigation over whether it was helping Chinese customers obtain advanced Nvidia chips subject to Washington's export controls.

Alice Huang has since been thrust into the spotlight because of her links with Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang. The two are not related.

The New York Times reported last month that US authorities had concluded she was a Chinese intelligence asset who passed information to Beijing while developing a close relationship with the Nvidia CEO.

Reuters could not independently verify the intelligence allegation, which China has denied. Reuters could not determine Alice Huang's whereabouts to seek comment.

Nvidia's board has launched an independent investigation into reports that its CEO was targeted by a foreign intelligence operation, but said it had no reason to believe national security information or company trade secrets had been compromised.

US President Donald Trump said on Monday that the FBI was also looking into the matter, but he did not provide further details.

Without commenting directly on Alice Huang, Jensen Huang acknowledged on Sunday being unfaithful to his wife, but said he was committed to supporting US national security.

Finance to chips

Alice Huang, reported by Chinese financial publication Caixin to be about 42 years old, previously worked in banking and investment management, according to Chinese fund-industry records and an indexed profile on private-fund database Simuwang, which also listed an earlier career in television journalism.

A screengrab from a video footage shows a woman identified as Alice Huang attending a dinner with Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang at a restaurant in Taipei, Taiwan on 22 May 2025. REUTERS

Before her involvement with Megaspeed, she held senior positions at Shanghai Hexi Investment Management, a Chinese investment firm.

Several posts on Hexi's official WeChat account between 2016 and 2017 identified her as the firm's deputy general manager, executive director and a member of its investment decision committee and said she had previously worked at HSBC's private bank in Hong Kong and at CITIC Securities. HSBC and CITIC did not immediately respond to requests for comment.

A Hexi business card reviewed by *Reuters* identified Alice Huang as a partner and general manager, with an office in Shanghai's Lujiazui financial district. At the Aurora Plaza address listed on the card, *Reuters* found offices undergoing extensive renovation, with no Hexi signage or staff present. Calls to a number on the card went unanswered, and an email address could not receive messages.

Huang became Megaspeed's controlling shareholder in March 2023, according to Washington-based research group C4ADS, which reviewed corporate records. Incorporated in Singapore in 2015 as 7Road International, Megaspeed provides cloud-computing services and describes itself on its company website as an Nvidia business partner in the Asia-Pacific region.

Huang also served as a director and managing director of Megaspeed's Indonesian subsidiary from March to November 2023, C4ADS said. Megaspeed did not respond to a request for comment.

At a party hosted by Taiwanese server manufacturer Gigabyte during the 2024 Computex technology trade show, Alice Huang and Jensen Huang were both present, according to a person who attended. A photograph posted on LinkedIn showed them seated next to each other.

US President Trump said on Monday he 'was amazed' by the allegations involving Jensen Huang

Gigabyte, which makes AI servers using Nvidia chips, did not respond to a request for comment.

Ties under scrutiny

Megaspeed has drawn scrutiny from US authorities over suspicions that it helped Chinese companies obtain advanced Nvidia chips subject to Washington's export restrictions, but there has been no public finding that it violated the rules.

Shipping records from trade-data provider ImportGenius reviewed by *Reuters* show Megaspeed's Indonesian subsidiary imported Nvidia hardware between 2024 and 2026, including H100 processors and related components, in shipments from suppliers including Gigabyte subsidiary Giga Computing.

The H100 is among the advanced Nvidia processors restricted from export to China, although the shipments to Indonesia do not themselves establish any violation of US export controls.

Megaspeed's shares were transferred in late 2023 to Singapore-based SwiftData, which holds all 10 million of its ordinary shares, according to C4ADS. Reuters could not immediately contact SwiftData.

C4ADS said it could not determine who ultimately controls SwiftData, but assessed that Alice Huang may have continued to exercise influence over Megaspeed after the transfer, citing appearances in which she was identified as its chair.

SEEKING ANSWERS

The reports of ties between Alice Huang and Jensen Huang have prompted US lawmakers to seek answers from the Nvidia CEO.

Central questions include whether he knew of any alleged intelligence activity and whether sensitive information was compromised, said George Chen, a partner at consultancy The Asia Group.

"In many respects, Jensen may also be viewed as a potential victim if he was deliberately targeted or manipulated without knowledge of the individual's true identity or intentions," Chen said.

The US chipmaker has said its CEO meets with thousands of customer executives each year, and that its cloud customers in Asia receive ordinary business information rather than trade secrets or information related to US national security.

Trump said on Monday he "was amazed" by allegations involving Jensen Huang, among the president's closest allies in Silicon Valley. Trump said he had spoken to the CEO, who told him that he had no idea that the woman was a spy.

Year-end holiday detour: how to find ways around soaring airfares

Domestic airfares have risen 30-40% in a year, prompting travellers to rethink their holiday plans this winter

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For Tobit Pinto, getting to Goa this New Year will take three days, two overnight stops and a detour through central India. Flying was quicker, but at over ₹30,000 a ticket, it was hardly worth the shortcut. So he turned the journey into a holiday of its own. When Pinto checked return airfares from Delhi to Goa for the year-end break, he found they would cost nearly ₹1 lakh for three people. Rather than give up the holiday, he and his sister and brother-in-law decided to drive, with stops in Indore for its street food and Nashik for its vineyards before reaching Goa.

After a week in Goa, the trio will return via Mumbai. "This plan has added two unique destinations to our itinerary, while bringing down transportation costs considerably," said Pinto, a UI/UX designer.

Pinto is among travellers finding creative ways to enjoy winter holidays despite soaring airfares. Some are swapping flights for trains and road trips, while others are choosing domestic over international destinations. Rather than cutting holiday budgets or compromising on experiences, they are changing how they travel to avoid spending a large share of their budgets on airfares.

According to Yatra Online, domestic airfares rose by 30-40% in a year, led by higher aviation fuel cost, weak rupee and constrained flight capacity.

"This year, we expect travellers to be more mindful of their budgets and deliberate in their planning, translating into advance bookings, shorter trips and greater consideration of destinations within driving distance of major cities," said Bharatt Malik, executive vice president, consumer business, Yatra Online.

Road trip

The three-day drive will cost an estimated ₹25,000-30,000 in fuel if the family alternates between CNG and petrol. "If we drive exclusively on petrol, fuel costs will jump to ₹50,000," Pinto said. Tolls could add another ₹6,000-7,000 for the trip.

Accommodation at the two stops, along with meals and experiences, will cost ₹15,000. This takes the estimated cost to ₹46,000- 70,000 for three people, compared with nearly ₹1 lakh for return flights alone.

The economics work because vehicle expenses are shared. Unlike airfares, which rise with each additional passenger, fuel and toll costs remain largely unchanged. However, driving takes more time and effort, and requires careful planning. Travellers must also account for parking and vehicle wear and tear.

Trains and experiences

Mumbai-based Neerav Shah has taken a different approach. His five-day December holiday combines two experiences: watching Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli play an India-Sri Lanka cricket match in Ahmedabad and tracking tigers at Ranthambore National Park.

Travelling solo from 19 to 23 December, Shah has built his itinerary around trains. "I like anchoring my trips around experiences. Watching RoKo (Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli) play and then doing multiple safaris trying to track tigers and just appreciating the sounds, sights, and smells of the forest is what excites me," he said.

Train tickets for the entire journey, including 2AC travel, cost ₹5,500. Four canter safaris at the national park will cost ₹4,000, while four-star accommodation in Sawai Madhopur, including meals, has been booked for ₹8,000. He expects match tickets to cost ₹1,000-2,000, stadium food another ₹1,000, and has set aside around ₹2,000 for other expenses. His total estimated expenditure is under ₹25,000.

Indians travellers are swapping flights for trains and road trips, or visiting domestic destinations, to manage costs

The itinerary was not his first choice. "Had airfares been reasonable, I would have done a 10-day holiday in Assam, particularly Kaziranga National Park," said Shah. Return flights from Mumbai to Guwahati around the same dates are selling for about ₹25,000, roughly the cost of his entire holiday.

But booking train tickets during the year-end rush was challenging.

"For the Ahmedabad-Sawai Madhopur leg, I couldn't find convenient options for my preferred journey. I had to book a longer route from Gandhidham to Kota in second AC, and then the final one-hour stretch from Kota to Sawai Madhopur, though in the same train, is in sleeper class," Shah said.

Shah's experience highlights a key trade-off: train travel can sharply reduce transport costs, but securing seats during peak season requires flexibility over boarding stations, classes and routes. "It takes some mental gymnastics with the IRCTC website to book tickets," he said.

For travellers willing to navigate these complications, the savings can go towards accommodation and activities rather than just getting to the destination.

Staying domestic

For Noida-based Dinesh Rathi, the question was whether an international holiday justified the added expense and uncertainty.

Rathi began planning for a Christmas-New Year break with three other families in September. Their first choices were Sri Lanka and Vietnam, but return flights from Delhi cost around ₹50,000-53,000 per person. "I had a budget of ₹3-3.5 lakh in mind for my family of four, but flights alone would have consumed over ₹2 lakh," Rathi added.

A weaker Indian currency only added to the concerns. Accommodation, food and activities abroad would cost more in rupee terms, while visa and foreign exchange expenses would add to the bill.

The group eventually chose Kerala, where return flights cost nearly half as much, at ₹28,000 per person. For Rathi's family, this means an airfare bill of around ₹1.12 lakh, against ₹2-2.12 lakh for Sri Lanka or Vietnam.

While the airfare savings are substantial, Rathi does not expect the domestic holiday to be significantly cheaper. "Luxury hotels in Kerala are expensive, and most of the money saved on airfares will be spent on costlier hotels," he said.

The decision also reflected the effort involved in planning an international holiday. A trip involving 14 people would require the group to track exchange rates and coordinate visa applications.

Even after flights and hotels are booked, the final cost could change with currency movements, particularly in destinations such as Sri Lanka, where most expenses are USD-denominated. "International holidays have added expenses such as international roaming, travel insurance, forex charges and some unforeseen surprises."

Kerala removes several of these variables. The group can estimate most major expenses in rupees before departure, making it easier for all four families to agree on a budget. "The domestic trip feels lightweight as it's predictable and we won't have to optimise everything. It feels less financially complicated," he said.

Until airfares ease, flexibility over destinations and travel modes can help holidaymakers manage costs without sacrificing experiences. Pinto gets two additional cities to explore, Shah has built his trip around experiences he enjoys, and Rathi has chosen a holiday with fewer financial uncertainties.

Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.

High airfares, no holiday blues

Domestic airfares have soared 30-40% in one year, but travellers are finding smarter ways to holiday during Christmas-New Year break.

Travellers' experiences

TOBIT PINTO, Delhi

Road trip from Delhi to Goa with sister and her husband

Route: Delhi → Indore → Nashik → Goa → Mumbai → Delhi

Costs

Fuel	upto ₹50,000
Tolls	₹6,000-7,000
Two overnight stops, meals	₹15,000
Total*	about ₹73,000 for three

**Does not include one overnight stay while returning to Delhi as they are yet to book it*

Why this plan?

- Return flight to Goa was over ₹30,000 per person

"Blowing up about ₹1 lakh on flights didn't feel smart. Road trip has added 2 unique destinations to our holiday, while also lowering the travel cost."

NEERAV SHAH, Mumbai

Train trip combining cricket in Ahmedabad and Tiger safaris in Ranthambore

Route: Mumbai → Ahmedabad → Ranthambore → Mumbai

Costs

Train tickets*	₹5,500
Four tiger safaris	₹4,000
Four-star hotel in Ranthambore with meals	₹8,000
Cricket match ticket	₹1,000-2,000
Stadium food, miscellaneous	₹3,000
Total	about ₹22,000

**for 2AC class, and last Kota to Sawai Madhopur leg in sleeper*

Why this plan?

- Kaziranga, Assam was the first choice, but direct return flights alone would cost ₹25,000

"Booking confirmed train tickets was challenging. I even had to change boarding station in Gujarat to get preferred seats. But the effort is worth the saving."

DINESH RATHI, Noida

Kerala holiday with 3 other families, in place of Sri Lanka or Vietnam

Plan: 8-day travel across Kerala

Costs

Return flights from Delhi	₹28,000 per person
Total budget	₹3 lakh - 3.5 lakh for four

Why this plan?

- Return flights to Sri Lanka or Vietnam were ₹50,000-53,000 per person, consuming over ₹2 lakh of the family budget
- About ₹90,000 saved in flights, but spent it on costlier luxury hotels in Kerala

"The domestic trip might cost only slightly less than Sri Lanka or Vietnam, but it feels more predictable without visa, forex worries."

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Forgot to report an overseas account? Use FAST-DS 2026

Harshal Bhuta

ASK MINT
NRI TAXATION

I have been an NRI residing in the UK since January 2024. In February and March 2024, I sold some listed US shares which I had invested in when I was an Indian resident. Being in the UK, I credited the proceeds to a newly opened UK bank account, which I use for personal expenses. Since I was a resident of India for Indian tax purposes for FY24-25, I disclosed the capital gains in my tax return for FY23-24 and paid tax on them, but inadvertently omitted reporting the UK bank account in Schedule FA. Under which category of FAST-DS 2026 (Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers – Disclosure Scheme) can I declare the account?

—Name withheld on request

Broadly, and subject to the prescribed conditions, FAST-DS 2026 covers two categories of declaration: (1) undisclosed foreign assets and income, with an aggregate value limit of ₹1 crore as on 31 March 2026; and (2) foreign assets not disclosed in Schedule FA, with an aggregate value not exceeding ₹5 crore as on 31 March 2026, where such assets were acquired out of income that has already been subjected to tax or while the taxpayer was a non-resident. These categories are subject to separate eligibility and valuation requirements.

To determine whether your UK bank account falls within the first category of FAST-DS 2026, it is necessary to carefully examine whether it qualifies as an undisclosed foreign asset. The term 'undisclosed foreign asset' under FAST-DS 2026 refers to an asset located outside India and held in the taxpayer's name, for which the taxpayer has no satisfactory explanation regarding the source of the investment.

Based on the facts you have shared, the funds credited to the UK bank account are identifiable as proceeds from the sale of foreign investments, and the related capital gains were disclosed and taxed in India.

Accordingly, the UK bank account would not qualify as an undisclosed foreign asset, and Category 1 of FAST-DS 2026 would not apply.

However, the UK bank account falls within the second category under FAST-DS 2026, which covers foreign assets not disclosed in Schedule FA, where the income used to acquire the assets has already been offered to tax. In view of these specific circumstances, you are eligible to declare the account under this category, provided its value as on 31 March 2026 does not exceed ₹5 crore.

For this purpose, the FAST-DS Rules, 2026 prescribe a specific method for valuing a bank account. Under this prescribed valuation method, the value is determined by adding all deposits made into the account from the date of its opening until 31 March 2026, excluding deposits made out of withdrawals from the same account.

If the UK bank account's value does not exceed ₹5 crore, you would be eligible to declare it under FAST-DS 2026 by paying the prescribed fee of ₹1 lakh, subject to fulfilling the other conditions.

Harshal Bhuta is co-founder and country co-head of International Tax and FEMA at Ascentium India, a Singapore-based professional services firm.

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at **mintmoney@livemint.com** and get them answered by industry experts.

FOREIGN EQUITIES UNDER PRESSURE: WHAT SHOULD YOU DO?

POWER POINT

V. KRISHNA DASSAN

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Indians, who have traditionally invested in the domestic equity markets, have increasingly ventured into overseas equities over the past two years, particularly in the past year. Remittances for overseas equity and debt investments more than doubled year-on-year to $321.5 million from $152.2 million.

Until recently, even investors who allocated money overseas largely restricted themselves to US stocks. However, the triple-digit returns delivered by South Korean and Taiwanese indices in 2025, driven by a spectacular rally in artificial intelligence (AI) and semiconductor stocks, brought these markets into sharper focus among Indian investors, particularly as domestic markets have been going through a rough patch for nearly two years.

The rally continued into 2026. In the year up to June, South Korea's Kospi delivered returns of 83%, Taiwan's market returned 51%, and the Nasdaq 100 gained 20%. However, since July, AI and semiconductor stocks have witnessed sell-offs, prompting investors to question whether they should continue holding foreign equities. The familiar tendency to react to recent market performance has resurfaced.

Diversification case

The primary objective of investing in foreign equities should be geographical diversification. Different countries offer exposure to varying economic cycles, industries, innovation ecosystems and growth opportunities. Investing globally also allows investors to participate in emerging themes such as AI, electric vehicles, energy transition and electronics, where certain overseas markets have a competitive advantage and India lags behind.

India accounts for only around 3% of global equity markets. Restricting investments entirely to domestic equities means missing exposure to the remaining 97% of the global opportunity set. This does not mean investors should allocate 97% of their portfolios to overseas equities, but it highlights the importance of looking beyond domestic markets.

BLOOMBERG

Global diversification can also help reduce excessive dependence on the fortunes of a single economy. India's long-term growth prospects remain attractive, but domestic equities can experience extended periods of underperformance or heightened volatility. This can be particularly pronounced during geopolitical disruptions such as the current one, which hurt India relatively more because of its heavy dependence on imported oil.

Past returns

The global rally in 2025 may have led investors to expect similar gains in subsequent years. But assuming markets delivering exceptional returns will continue to outperform is not rational or realistic. Markets move in cycles, and leadership shifts. Diversification recognises that asset classes, geographies and sectors perform differently across cycles, with no single market consistently outperforming others. Past returns should not be the sole basis for choosing a country, index or asset class.

Stay invested

Exiting overseas investments merely because they are underperforming a correction could defeat the purpose of diversification. Investors who exit during downturns risk turning a long-term allocation decision into short-term performance chasing. Foreign equities, like domestic equities, are subject to market volatility, currency fluctuations and geopolitical risks. The response to a correction should depend on whether the original investment rationale has changed, the portfolio's overall allocation and the investor's time horizon, rather than on the market decline alone.

Periodic portfolio reviews and rebalancing can help investors maintain their intended asset allocation without making reactive decisions based on short-term market movements. The sharp rally in global equities over the past two years also warrants a review, as the appreciation in asset values may have altered the intended allocation.

Concentration risks

While geographical diversification is important, investors must also examine the underlying composition of the markets they invest in. Indices in Taiwan and South Korea, for instance, are significantly influenced by a handful of large technology and semiconductor companies. Their performance can therefore be disproportionately affected by developments in the AI ecosystem. Investors should consider broad-based indices such as the S&P 500, which provide exposure to companies across multiple sectors, as well as actively managed overseas equity portfolios that diversify across geographies, sectors and investment themes. This can help reduce dependence on a single industry or a small group of stocks.

Investors should avoid chasing recent winners or exiting during corrections

Strategic allocation

Foreign equities should form part of a well-considered asset allocation strategy rather than being treated as a short-term bet on the next outperforming market. Investors with moderate or aggressive risk profiles may consider allocating 20-30% of their equity portfolio to global equities. The appropriate allocation depends on an investor's financial goals, investment horizon, risk appetite and existing portfolio.

V. Krishna Dassan, director, Dhanavruksha Financial Services.

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OUR VIEW

HT

Making hospital bills more transparent

The government's plan to start an online portal for prices of medical procedures is laudable but it won't help patients. Singapore's protocols could serve as a model for India to emulate

The government is planning an online portal where private hospitals would post prices for medical procedures, *Mint* reported last month ('Private hospitals may have to go public with tariffs on services,' 28 October). The aim is to improve transparency by making information easily accessible. While the intent is laudable, this policy is unlikely to be of much help to patients.

Even when hospitals stick to benchmark rates for standard treatment options, they would always have a fair amount of discretion in extending stay, or inflating the price of 'consumables' to raise the final bill for the patient. India's past experience with medical price caps isn't inspiring. After coronary stent prices were capped in 2017, private hospitals performed disproportionately more angioplasties relative to bypass surgeries. Complications requiring additional tests add another layer of uncertainty to hospital tariffs. Evidence from the US for similar tools is not encouraging.

India needs a more sophisticated strategy to regulate healthcare pricing. Policymakers would do well to study the Singapore model closely, and try to adapt it to Indian realities. Three aspects deserve close attention. *First*, Singapore offers a more careful approach to bridge the information gap between medical providers and patients. Patients receive financial counselling before they get admitted: an estimate of the total bill and how much their insurance plan is likely to cover. Singapore's health ministry also publishes data collated from actual or realized bills: how much patients have been charged for different procedures, showing typical amounts and ranges. This gives a better idea of the actual costs compared to theoretical benchmark rates. The National Health Authority's Ayushman Bharat claims and insurance data could be tapped to prepare such a database in India.

Second, Singapore has institutionalized random audits of medical providers to ensure that patients are treated fairly. Fee benchmarks for surgeons, anaesthetists and private hospitals are set by an independent committee representing doctors, insurers and consumers. Providers found to have overcharged patients or filed inappropriate insurance claims face penalties. Before such a model is implemented in India, the Union government would need to partner with state governments to re-haul the medical regulation infrastructure across the country.

Third, Singapore also manages cross-subsidisation transparently. Public hospitals offer wards ranging from unsubsidised single rooms to multi-bed subsidised wards. Citizens in subsidised wards receive means-tested support. Those who want privacy pay the full cost. Data on ward availability and pricing can be far more transparent in India than it is today.

In the Indian context, policymakers also need to pay attention to supply constraints in the country. High prices to some extent reflect the shortage of quality services and hospital beds. The expansion of medical colleges has outpaced faculty and clinical training. The National Exit Test proposed by the National Medical Commission for certifying eligible medical professionals needs to be rolled out soon. Periodic re-licensing should be linked to continuing education. The empanelment of insurance firms should be linked to published outcome indicators, and operate through a well-oiled accreditation system.

THEIR VIEW

India needs to shed its defensive ways to trade and sustainability

India should define what sustainable development means to it and not accept foreign impositions

R.V. ANURADHA
is partner, Clarus Law Associates

Sustainable development" has become a defining feature of any trade agreement. While there is no formal definition of this term, its essence continues to be governed by the 1987 United Nations Brundtland Commission report titled *Our Common Future*, which explained it as "Development meeting the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs."

Sustainability rests on three pillars: social, comprising labour and human rights; economic, which is the trade dimension; and environment, which relates to natural resource management and conservation.

India was initially sceptical of building-in obligations relating to environment and labour in its trade agreements, the concern being that selective use of such obligations in trade agreements would render them to be used as protectionist tools to vitiate trade obligations, rather than achieve any meaningful environmental or labour-related objectives. Economists such as the renowned Jagdish Bhagwati and Paul Krugman had also questioned the economic case for such requirements and their potential use for protectionism.

Sustainability, however, is not alien to Indian thought. The judiciary has recognized the concept of sustainable development as integral to Indian law, while emphasizing that this would involve a balancing of employment and livelihood concerns as well as competing environmental priorities.

India's FTAs with the European Union (EU) and the UK are important milestones in that they contain comprehensive chapters on sustainability. However, neither addresses the elephant in the room, which is the increasing use of unilateral measures in the UK and the EU. Both have introduced the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) which will require importers of products from India to pay the price differential per tonne of CO_2 between India and the EU and the UK, respectively. The price of CO_2 cannot be uniform. The International Monetary Fund's proposal for an international carbon price floor, acknowledged by the World Bank and the World Trade Organization, is that countries should not face one global common price, but that differentiation based on levels of development would need to be considered. CBAM does not account for that differential. It will hurt Indian exports in iron and steel, aluminium, cement and chemicals.

Concerns among India and other countries over CBAM and other EU green-deal measures, such as the EU Deforestation Regulation (EUDR), Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (CS3D) and Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive (CSRD), are often dismissed as lack of concern for the environment or as fear of enhanced compliance. But this misconstrues and misses the point entirely. The concern is not that environmental or human rights measures are not critical. Instead, the concern lies in the unilateral imposition and extra-territorial application of another country's requirements. It will not be enough for India to ensure compliance with its international law obligations relating to environment, climate change or labour rights; or for Indian companies to certify compliance with Indian laws. Rather, EUDR will require Indian exporters in coffee, leather, rubber, wood, handicrafts, paper, paperboard and soymeal to provide precise geolocation data and traceability and certification that they are not produced in deforested land. CS3D requires importers to map risks in the supply chain (suppliers of raw materials, manufacturing, components) on compliance with international environmental and human rights obligations, whose validity will be open to EU scrutiny and assessment. CSRD mandates a sustainability disclosure framework based on EU requirements. The compliance burden will be the heaviest for small and medium enterprises.

India's FTAs with the EU and UK do not address these fundamental concerns. The one with the EU, in fact, implicitly acknowledges CBAM's legitimacy, with an annexure devoted to it that notes that any CBAM concession that the EU provides to another country would be available to India.

Tariff liberalization is no longer the cornerstone of FTAs. Instead, the value of FTAs will depend on the extent to which they can afford predictable, sustainable market access. Take for example the perils of climate change. FTAs can play a positive role by facilitating the transfer of environmentally sensitive technologies, accelerating the flow of green financing, investments into environmental goods and services and the development of resilient and trust-based relationships between trading partners.

There cannot be a one-size-fits-all version of sustainability that applies across countries. FTAs need to acknowledge and address this reality. Mere extra-territorial application of another country's requirements will not achieve sustainable development for either country. Instead, India needs to own its vision of sustainability and negotiate more meaningful provisions in its FTAs.

These are the author's personal views.

10 YEARS AGO

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THOMAS FRIEDMAN

GUEST VIEW

The world requires a new approach to energy security

SOUMYA SARKAR

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Every war that threatens energy supplies exposes the price of depending on fossil fuels. And the immediate response is to secure more of them. Governments scramble for alternative suppliers, replenish strategic reserves and protect supply routes.

Economies cannot wait for a transition to resolve an immediate crisis, but this response perpetuates the vulnerability that made it costly. At the annual climate summit in Türkiye's Antalya that is currently underway, can energy security become a reason to hasten the transition rather than an excuse to postpone it?

Europe's response to the Ukraine war shows the limits of diversification. The European Union reduced Russia's share of its gas imports from 45% in 2021 to 12% in 2025, but much of the replacement came from other suppliers and expanded infrastructure. Dependence on one supplier fell but reliance on imported fuel did not.

For Asia, tensions around the Strait of Hormuz due to the Iran war again expose the vulnerability.

Around 20 million barrels of crude a day passed through the waterway in 2025, accounting for a quarter of the global seaborne oil trade. Of it, 80% was destined for Asia. Diversifying suppliers cannot protect an economy from a disruption that pushes up prices across the global market.

The energy transition will also not end geopolitical competition. It will merely change what countries compete over. Control of critical-mineral processing, battery materials and clean-energy technologies is becoming as strategically important as access to oil and gas.

The International Energy Agency says China dominates processing of most of the refined supply of key energy minerals, while Indonesia leads in nickel. Building alternative supply chains is essential but expensive. Capital costs for refining projects outside dominant suppliers can be 20% to more than 150% higher. The transition is, therefore, also a contest over industrial capacity, technology and access.

The money involved makes this a defining economic shift. BloombergNEF estimates global energy-transition investment reached a record $2.3 trillion in 2025 led by electrified transport, renewable energy and power grids. Yet, growth slowed to 8% from 27% in 2021.

Investment and manufacturing capacity also remain unevenly distributed.

India shows what is at stake. Its dependence on imported crude has remained around 88%, leaving it exposed to global price shocks despite diversifying suppliers. Renewables have begun to reduce that exposure. The International Energy Agency's latest assessment says renewable power capacity crossed 300 gigawatts in the first quarter of 2026, almost quadrupling in a decade.

More consequentially, solar, wind and bioenergy reduced cumulative spending on coal and natural-gas imports by more than $100 billion between 2011 and 2025. Without renewable capacity added since 2010, coal imports in 2025 would have been around 110 million tonnes higher. Clean energy is already delivering an economic-security dividend.

Cooperation is a better bet than doubling down on fossil fuels or trading one dependency for another

But success in electricity should not be mistaken for energy independence. Renewables supplied about a quarter of India's electricity in 2025, while oil remains central to transport and industry. Dependence on gas imports is projected to rise from 52% in 2024 to around 71% by 2030. India must, therefore, extend electrification beyond power generation and address constraints in grids, storage and distribution finances. BloombergNEF estimates India attracted $72 billion in energy-transition investment in 2025, but wind and solar alone will require $123-163 billion through 2030. That gap reflects the infrastructure India must build to reduce fuel-import exposure.

No country can meet this challenge through self-sufficiency in every mineral, component and technology. Global and bilateral cooperation must diversify processing and manufacturing, enable technology transfer and expand recycling. It must also make finance more affordable. Developing economies face higher borrowing costs. If access to capital and technology remains unequal, the transition will be slower and more expensive, when reducing fossil-fuel dependence could deliver the greatest strategic benefit.

The 35-by-35 Global Electrification Pledge of this year's summit, which seeks to raise electricity's share of global final energy consumption to 35% by 2035, offers a practical test. Electrification needs more than renewable capacity.

It requires modern grids, storage, system flexibility and finance that developing countries are able to afford. The summit must turn this recognition into partnerships and investment, not another ambition left to national budgets.

Wars may continue to disrupt energy markets, and governments will protect their immediate interests. But a world that responds to every fossil-fuel shock by securing more oil and gas is condemned to repeat the same vulnerability. The real measure of energy security is not how successfully a country secures its next shipment, but how progressively it reduces the need for one. The Türkiye summit has an opportunity to make that a shared strategic objective.

MY VIEW | ECONOMIC GRAVITY

Let the budget focus on building resilience and driving reforms

It must strengthen fiscal credibility, build cushions against shocks and make growth job-rich for India's goals to be achieved

PRACHI MISHRA
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PTI

On 1 February, the finance minister will present the budget for an economy that has done better than most expected, under conditions worse than anticipated. This resilience should give policymakers room to manage the shock while pressing ahead with deeper reforms.

Real gross domestic product (GDP) grew 7.8% in the April-June quarter. Private consumption contributed almost four percentage points, buoyed by the goods and services tax (GST) 2.0 reforms. Micro indicators agree: vehicle registrations are rising and bank credit growth is near 20%.

The global environment calls for vigil. Brent crude oil was about $70 a barrel before the West Asia war began in late February and rose above $115 after September's East-West pipeline shutdown. Political uncertainty in the US has also grown: with the opposition set to control both houses of Congress, policy on issues key to India, including the war, tariffs and trade deals, is less predictable.

At home, the external shock shows up in three places. Headline inflation in September was 2.8 percentage points higher than in January, and above the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) 4% target. Foreign portfolio investors have been net sellers in most of this year, and the rupee slid to about 95 to the dollar. And the fiscal arithmetic has changed.

Estimates by Ashoka's Isaac Centre for Public Policy (ICPP) help size the challenge. If energy disruption lasts until December, lower excise collections, higher fertilizer and liquified petroleum gas subsidies and smaller oil-company dividends can push the 2026-27 fiscal deficit to about 4.86% of GDP, against a target of 4.3%, equivalent to a slippage of ₹2.4 trillion. If it lasts until March 2027, the deficit can jump to 4.94%.

The budget can turn this into an opportunity. Recognizing the war-related overshoot as a one-off while protecting capital expenditure would preserve the public spending that crowds-in private investment. The government's reaffirmed debt anchor of 50% of GDP by 2030-31 should also reassure markets, which matters more now that India is part of global bond indices. Rating agencies weigh debt heavily and higher tax revenue along with a full disclosure of contingent liabilities would strengthen India's case for an upgrade. The Centre could nudge the states towards a common framework for using GST data and simplifying compliance, widening their tax base. States too could share GST revenues with urban local bodies, which gave up octroi under GST.

Shocks are now more frequent. Foreign exchange reserves, though drawn on to steady the rupee, are adequate by most measures, including ICPP estimates; But India's strategic oil reserves cover just about 5 days of net imports, and 26 with commercial stocks, short of the International Energy Agency's 90-day benchmark. Expanding them, and hedging part of the government's oil exposure as insurance, would cushion the next shock.

India's Viksit Bharat aim rests on two goals: a high-income economy and a larger number of good jobs. *First*, at recent trend growth in per-capita dollar income, India would reach the World Bank's high-income threshold well beyond 2047. Getting there by 2047 needs close to 8% a year real GDP growth sustained for two decades.

The *second* is even more challenging and makes job-rich growth imperative. The latest Periodic Labour Force Survey shows unemployment among 15-29-year-olds at 16%, three times the overall rate, and 18% among urban youth. Yet, manufacturing, the classic jobs engine, has stayed at 15-16% of gross value added for a decade. Since 2000, exports have shifted from textiles and clothing towards capital-intensive machinery. A proactive effort to rebalance towards labour-intensive sectors would play to India's comparative advantage and create more jobs; rising automation in global manufacturing makes this more urgent.

Data on listed and unlisted companies point to robust growth in private corporate capital expenditure. Net foreign direct investment is rising from a low base, though only about a fifth of gross inflows go to manufacturing. Partnerships such as Japan's 10 trillion yen investment pledge can help if foreign plants set root in Indian supplier networks.

The budget should *first* tilt incentives towards employment in sectors such as apparel, footwear, leather, food processing and electronics assembly. *Second*, rationalize tariffs on intermediate inputs and cut the time, cost, complexity and uncertainty of moving goods across borders, embedding Indian firms in global value chains; a logistics cost index for Exim trade being built by the ministry of ports, shipping and waterways with ICPP can complement the National Time Release Study in tracking progress. *Third*, prioritize tax stability, certainty of interpretation through advance rulings, faster dispute resolution through new bilateral investment treaties, and state-level implementation of the labour codes. *Fourth*, help firms, especially smaller ones, seize the opportunities opened by India's new free trade and economic partnership agreements. *Fifth*, ease tax compliance for foreign portfolio investors: the bank that already acts as an authorized dealer and custodian could compute, pay and report the investor's tax. *Sixth*, mobilize idle household gold, some 35,000 tonnes. Drawing on cross-country experience, RBI could incentivize banks by letting them hold part of their reserve requirements in recycled gold, with the mobilized metal lent to jewellers and manufacturers. Unlike oil, where India is a major exporter of refined products, its gold refineries run at under half their roughly 1,800-tonne capacity. Feeding them recycled gold would cut imports and lift exports. ICPP research adds a safeguard: modest yields, short tenures and eligibility screens, so deposits do not induce fresh purchases.

Finally, play to strengths. Services trade now exceeds 15% of GDP, India's workforce is far less exposed to AI substitution than that of advanced economies, and the demographic window is still open. Prioritizing skill development and services exports can unlock the true value of trade deals.

In an uncertain world, two priorities hold: cushioning the economy against shocks and making growth job-rich. The budget can deliver on both.

MINT CURATOR

Why forecasts of the US jobs report are so off the mark now

American statistics agencies have had to do more with fewer funds

JONATHAN LEVIN
is a columnist focused on US markets and economics.

Jobs data is going to remain volatile and unpredictable. AP

Yet again, the economic soothsayers couldn't have been more wrong about the latest report on the state of the US labour market released last week, adding to a mounting string of errant forecasts and raising an obvious question: Why do the people who make a living forecasting one of the most important data points in the whole economy get it so wrong so often?

The Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) said non-farm payrolls expanded by 165,000 in October, more than twice the median estimate of 70,000 in a Bloomberg survey of more than 70 economists. None of the forecasts came close, with the highest estimate being 131,000. Should we be concerned about the consistently wide divergence between what economists anticipate and the actual results, both on the upside and the downside? Yes, for the simple reason that it adds to unnecessary volatility in financial markets. But it's not the result of some government conspiracy to manipulate the data or forecaster incompetence.

Let's start with the recent misses. The 95,000 gap between what economists were expecting for October and the actual numbers wasn't even the biggest of the year. Estimates for February, March, July and August were off by more than 100,000 each of those months. The average size of the miss, ignoring whether it missed low or high, has been around 88,000 in 2026, up from about 50,000 in 2010-2019, the period that I'm using as a proxy for 'normal.'

This is, to a significant degree, the predictable result of the decision to forgo investment in America's statistics agencies, long considered the world's gold standard but lately forced to do the best that they can with shrinking resources. In inflation-adjusted terms, BLS funding has fallen well over 20% since 2010, and the second Trump administration would have instituted deeper cuts still if lawmakers hadn't pushed back. It's no surprise then that sample sizes are shrinking and the BLS is struggling to counter the problem of getting enough people to respond to its surveys.

"Declining response rates are happening everywhere," former BLS commissioner Erika McEntarfer told the *Financial Times* in July. "That's largely because people and businesses are harder to reach than they used to be. But another factor is that field resources are taking the biggest hit from those budget cuts. Because people have gotten harder to reach, it actually costs more to reach them, but we don't have the money for those resources — so that's also impacting response."

All of that leads to larger error bands around the published numbers. Looked at in those terms, no one should be shocked that the numbers look more choppy than they did a decade ago. With the 90% confidence interval currently around 122,000, changes smaller than that are statistically indistinguishable from zero—and indeed that's been the case for around half of jobs reports in 2026.

That brings me to a second point—that it's hard to predict labour market growth that's this statistically close to zero. The Trump administration's restrictions on legal immigration and its fear campaign against the undocumented population have stanched the flow of labour into the US economy, and this is one side effect. We're dealing in job gains that by historical standards are so small that they're often hard for economists and statisticians to differentiate from normal month-to-month noise.

One final bit of nuance: The BLS estimates payrolls by surveying a representative sample of establishments, but one challenge is that new employers are always being created or going out of business. The government fills the gap with what it is known as the birth-death model that has changed over time. The old model basically extrapolated stale data into the current period on a fairly smooth basis. That's great if you're an economist trying to guess the next report but not-so-great if you're trying to understand what is really happening in the economy. As of January 2026, the BLS instituted a new model that combines the extrapolation with more contemporaneous information, making it inherently more volatile. Does it work better? That remains to be seen at this early juncture, but it's definitely harder to forecast.

The thing to hold onto is that this data is going to remain volatile and unpredictable, and labour market-watchers would be well served by focusing on longer-term trends instead of getting too worked up about individual reports. Last week's strong number was certainly nice, but it's hard to tell if there's much signal in it. Meanwhile, policymakers must finally work to expand funding to the BLS and return to the task of creating sensible immigration policy that gives the economy the workers we need. Maybe then we can start producing some payroll gains that are statistically distinguishable from zero. ©BLOOMBERG

MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

Can regulatory technology reliably enable compliance?

RAHUL MATTHAN

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I have long argued that we need to make our law legible to digital systems. As early as 2016, I spoke of the promise of regulatory technology, or regtech, and argued that if we could build compliance into the infrastructure, we could dramatically change how we enforce it. More recently, Manish Sabharwal and I made the case for establishing a single source of truth—one canonical repository of every instrument that has the power to legally bind us, accessible for all to see. It would make the law available in a legislative markup language for India so that the digital systems that automate compliance can directly engage with it.

But even when this ambition comes to pass, it will only address compliance obligations at one end of the spectrum. Making statutory instruments machine-readable in a consolidated repository will help ensure that all statutory obligations are expressed in a quasi-structured format that is more accessible and actionable. What it cannot do is incorporate obligations that arise from judicial pronouncements, which have as much of a binding effect on us as laws enacted by the legislature and regulations issued by the executive.

Consider, for example, the *Vishaka* case. In 1997, the Supreme Court laid down guidelines on sexual harassment in the workplace that bound every employer in the country, and for the next 16 years—until Parliament enacted the Prevention of Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act in 2013—the only place those obligations existed was in the text of the judgment. Any compliance system that only automatically indexed every regulation in force would have overlooked them entirely. Yet, it was essential for companies across the country to comply with the obligations set out in the judgment, even though no statute required them to.

Vishaka is not an anomaly. Every time a court reads down a provision or reads new requirements into it, obligations change, even though not a word of the statute has.

For regtech solutions to provide the most up-to-date compliance architecture for their clients, they must also consider the impact of judicial pronouncements on their outputs. The way they do that today is by engaging armies of humans to manually enter these obligations into their systems. They have to, because, as mathematician Terence Tao pointed out, we have the mathematics for highly structured data and the mathematics for pure noise, but not for what lies in between. That messy middle is the precise spot that judicial pronouncements occupy.

It is easy to see why traditional software might struggle with this, but surely large language models (LLMs) can handle this much better. If carefully prompted to identify every new obligation a given judgment imposes, an LLM should be able to extract them with sufficient accuracy to meet our requirements.

A breakthrough in figuring how AI models reach an answer can help regulatory repositories stay updated

The trouble is that LLMs are far from consistent. Asked the same question at different times, they will most likely give a different answer each time. Until we can understand how and why a given model reaches the many different conclusions that it does, we will not be able to rely on LLMs to plug the judgment gap in the automation of compliance tech. It is not until we can be reliably sure that the model will always reach the same finding every time it is asked to analyse a given judgment that we will be able to depend on it.

To better understand why large language models behave as they do, frontier artificial intelligence (AI) laboratories have been working on the science of interpretability. In 2025, Anthropic's researchers published maps of how their model arrives at an answer, showing, for instance, that it decides what the rhyme at the end of a line should be before it begins writing it.

Until recently, it was believed that this work of interpretability could only be done indirectly, since each neuron in a model was thought to carry so many unrelated concepts superimposed on one another that it was not feasible to read what concepts each of them influenced. Last month, a researcher at interpretability lab Goodfire, who had helped develop the theory of superposition, reversed his stance, reporting that nearly nine in 10 neurons in the open-weight model he was studying performed one identifiable job. This seems to suggest that it should be possible to trace each step a model takes to arrive at an answer, and thereby identify the ones its conclusion actually depends on.

If this is true, we should be able to use this technology to reliably get an LLM to extract structured obligations from unstructured text—like that in a legal judgment. We should be able to see which passages it relies on, test whether it correctly identifies the right obligations every time it is asked, and find the places where it is merely guessing. If we can audit extraction in this manner, we will eventually be able to trust it more fully.

If we can do this, it would give our quest for a single source of truth an additional important layer. We will be able to ensure that alongside every statute, we also present the obligations our courts interpreted it to imply—extracted by machine, dated and duly revised every time a new judgment is delivered.

While the technology is still young, this is likely what we need in order to make AI more understandable to us. And while we are some distance from doing this at scale, the repositories we design today should be built keeping in mind that this is something we will eventually need to include.

How tech businesses are connecting with consumers

Tech marketing is everywhere, so brands are leaning on art and artists to create a lasting impression on prospective consumers

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GETTY IMAGES

Actor Billy Zane in *Bill Pay: The Musical*.

In October, Polymarket, a cryptocurrency-based prediction market, slipped its brand into a fortune cookie. "Yes, we paid for a fortune cookie ad," read the message, alongside a QR code. This unusual ad has sparked a debate about where advertising belongs.

During a recent visit to San Francisco, where almost every possible space seemed to feature a technology ad, there was a dance workshop with K-pop choreographer Kyle Hanagami, hosted by Netic (an AI revenue engine) that I wanted to attend. Then there was the news that insurance startup Corgi reportedly tried to open over 100 cafés, but health authorities closed its Dogpatch SF outlet for operating without a valid health permit. Meanwhile Ramp, a corporate finance and AI intelligence platform, took its AI-powered bill-payment software to Broadway with *Bill Pay: The Musical*, starring Tony winner Billy Porter, *Titanic* actor Billy Zane and *Wicked* star Jessica Vosk.

It's as if tech firms are trying to develop a cool extracurricular life. Their marketing is borrowing from entertainment, art, hospitality and everyday rituals to try and reach people beyond the regular product pitch. As AI makes it easier to build businesses and produce promotional content, the competition for attention is intensifying. Standing out means giving people a human reason to pause, participate, spread the word and remember a tech firm beyond the screen.

STRIKING A CONNECTION

There are some distinctions though: there's guerrilla marketing, using unconventional placements or interventions to attract attention outside standard advertising slots; while experiential marketing lets people participate, and brand building develops familiarity over time. But these approaches can also overlap. Indian software companies were doing this before the AI boom, like when Zoho offered free pedicab rides around Salesforce's Dreamforce conference in 2013. Freshworks flew a Failsforce blimp in 2018. Both reached prospective customers gathered by a competitor.

Plum, an insurance-tech platform, is taking another route. Insurance renewal is an annual decision, explains Chennai-based Ganapathi Ramanathan, 29, its general manager of marketing. To stay relevant between renewals, he looked beyond his customers' professional roles. "They're an employee with budgets, but they're also a friend, a spouse, a parent, and more," he says. Learning that many clients treasured reading to their children, inspired Plum's ESOP's Fables—a corporate version of Aesop's fables about inclusion, mental health and workplace values. Their wider repertoire includes the card game Cards Against Work, the workplace publication Humanise and insurance ASMR videos. "These complement conventional marketing, giving customers a reason to return beyond policy renewal," he says.

A ROOM WORTH REMEMBERING

For Bengaluru-based Abhay Jani, 30, co-founder of product community The Product Folks, the brief from tech partners has shifted towards curation and experience. His team has worked with companies including Anthropic, OpenAI, Replit and Wispr Flow across over than 20 cities, he says.

At a Speakeasy with Wispr Flow event in Bengaluru this August, visitors dictated stories for a shared wall, tested their writing speed using voice, and swung a foam hammer at a giant DELETE key. Jani says more than 1,500 people registered and over 800 attended through the day. "Every activity was the product," he says. For a voice-typing tool, participation became the demonstration. Similarly, OpenAI brought developers aboard a moving Pune Metro train to build with Codex. The unusual setting offered a story to share.

> The marketing strategies of tech firms are borrowing from entertainment, art, and everyday rituals to reach people

An experience can stay with someone long after the company's name has slipped one's mind. Copenhagen-based neuroscientist Dr Thomas Zoëga Ramsøy, founder and CEO of Neurons, a consumer neuroscience and marketing AI company, offers a brand linkage test: "Will people remember that it was you?" His advice is to make the brand visible when attention peaks and prioritise places where buyers make decisions, including sales conversations and the opening seconds of demo videos.

Corgi has made the café itself part of the strategy where founders can return, work and meet other builders. Other brands paid a monthly fee in the thousands of dollars for sponsored drinks. The café became a distribution channel as well as a venue for tech events. I even considered hosting an SF Tech Week storytelling workshop there.

Unexpected collaborations bring together audiences that might otherwise never meet. For example, Apple's recent Diwali collaboration with Raw Mango, a luxury Indian fashion label, illustrated how entertainment can carry product meaning. The tech giant's ad film Step Into the Light combines textiles, dance and festive imagery, showcasing the iPhone 18 Pro's camera capabilities. Similarly, Voice AI company Cartesia celebrated Diwali with A.R. Rahman in San Francisco, in an intimate gathering of founders and investors.

However, while doing quirky activities is in vogue, brands need to be cognizant of the fact that once a campaign enters the public eye, audiences can become both cheerleaders and critics. Praise, backlash and debate carry it beyond the brand's channels, often turning the campaigns into case studies.

KEEPING SURPRISE ALIVE

Of the usual storytelling tools of action, conflict and reversal, tech marketing seems especially fond of reversal. CRED's 2021 Rahul Dravid ad landed because the famously calm cricketer lost his cool. But then, its following campaigns became formulaic, as the company failed to maintain the element of surprise in its storytelling. For successful campaigns, Dr Ramsøy emphasises consistent, distinctive branding over isolated viral moments. Novelty can earn a brand the first look, but only continuity can turn it into recognition.

ChatGPT India's Instagram micro-series *The Grand Return*, featuring actress Revathy as an older woman returning to work at an agency with younger colleagues, creates that opportunity through episodic storytelling. Her internship is keeping viewers hooked while showcasing AI in work and life situations they recognise. Companies clearly need both sustained storytelling and concentrated spectacles for effective advertising.

WHAT STAYS AFTER THE LAUNCH?

Product launches now come with short films and videos engineered to go viral. Events have photo booths, cool merch and moments designed to create FOMO. For an event to be a success, brands are looking for deeper connections that can outlast the event. For Ramanathan, Plum's advertisements function within a larger relationship supported by service, consultants and product experience. His description for this is "cultural capital"—associations that accumulate beyond an immediate sales conversation.

Ramsøy suggests testing those associations before committing a large budget. Predictive AI tools can estimate attention patterns earlier in production, with deeper custom research reserved for bigger investments, he says. "I see data as a way to reduce guesswork and give creative teams more confidence to experiment."

There is something rather wholesome about an industry selling automation commissioning artists, playwrights, dancers, designers and musicians to make consumers care about the product. AI can test where the eye goes, but human storytelling is giving it a reason to linger. As the fortune cookie crumbles, whether the brand survives in our memory is the prediction worth making.

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REVIEW | MIJIA SMART AIR PURIFIER 6

Is this actually the best air purifier on the market?

The Mijia Air Purifier proved its worth during Delhi's heavily polluted Diwali

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With Diwali having just come and gone, I was wondering if my eyes were deceiving me. With AQI readings reaching well over 1500, I was stunned to see my air purifier with a reading well below 50.

The Xiaomi Mijia Smart Air Purifier 6 delivered on the most important pollution explosion day in Delhi, and how. I've tested a number of air purifiers over the years, and all of them failed to get the air quality to below even 100 on the day of Diwali.

Xiaomi recently unveiled its smart home and lifestyle-focused brand Mijia in India, and a slew of products are slowly being launched. The first among them is the Mijia Smart Air Purifier 6 (₹17,999) and Mijia Air Purifier 4 Compact.

A MODERN DESIGN

The Mijia Smart Air Purifier 6 gets a modern look, with a square-ish form factor with rounded corners, and a generally sleek look. It's one of those purifiers that can sit in the corner of a room and be unassuming, yet striking. The bottom half of the device is where the dirty air is drawn in with small air-intake pores. The top of the air purifier is where the clean air is expelled. There's a small circular display at the front of the device for seeing the readings and performing some basic tasks.

Unboxing and setting up of the air purifier is very simple and it seamlessly connects to the Xiaomi Home app, which is compatible with both Android and iPhone smartphones.

> When outdoors AQI was at 1500 on Diwali, the air purifier was giving a reading of 50 indoors

LARGE COVERAGE AREA

The Mijia Smart Air Purifier 6 can cover a fairly large area, up to 940sqft. I had it in the living room (which also houses the dining room), the biggest room in my house and it worked without a hitch.

The one thing you've got to understand is that while the 'auto mode' may function as intended, it is quite slow. It takes almost half an hour to go from poor to excellent AQI. If you want to speed this up, then you've got to change it to the highest level in manual mode. According to Xiaomi, this air purifier can remove harmful elements from the air within three and a half minutes, with the device at maximum fan speed. Even on the day of Diwali, I noticed that it didn't take longer than five minutes.

There is a primary filter and a Xiaomi High-Efficiency Filter, and between them the air purifier removes pollutants as well as odours, harmful gases and volatile organic compounds. There's also a UV light to help prevent bacterial growth on the display, and negative ions to neutralise dust and smoke. Xiaomi says that the filters can last between 6-12 months, depending on the use.

Replacement filters are priced at ₹5,499 on the company's website. The purifiers come with an integrated RFID tag in the filter assembly, which means means that aftermarket filters are not an option.

VERDICT

The Xiaomi Mijia Smart Air Purifier 6 is easy to recommend. It's got a good amount of filtration capabilities, an easy-to-use app, affordable replacement filters, and a clean and premium design. The only unknown is if Xiaomi can maintain a steady supply of filters one to two years down the road. If they can, then this becomes one of the best options in the market.

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When design and practically meet in the form of useful appliances

Appliances that lead with thoughtful design can also be very useful. Just don't expect the world from them

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There was a time when everyday home appliances were expected to do one thing, do it well, and then disappear into the background. Not anymore. There's a new generation of what I call "Instagram-ready home appliances" that are as much about thoughtful design that can be displayed front and center around your home, as they are about getting the functional basics right. Nuuk is a prime example of this shift, with Halo Fan, Brisk Air Fryer and Strom Garment Steamer. However, do they offer meaningful improvements over conventional alternatives, or are they just pretty faces? Here's how they stack up.

HĀLO V2 3D AIR CIRCULATION FAN

This isn't your bog-standard pedestal fan. The Halo v2 has an almost sculptural design with a compact circular base, slim stem and a distinctive fan head that looks like something out of an Ikea catalog. A touch of colour would have been nice, but it's available only in black and white. The fan costs ₹10,499.

The minimalist design isn't merely for show but is a functional choice, giving the Halo the ability to feature both horizontal oscillation (120 degrees) and vertical oscillation (90 degrees), allowing it to distribute air around a room rather than simply blast it in the horizontal plane.

Three BLDC motors power the airflow, giving the fan twelve wind speeds and four modes (wave, sleep, eco and hi). These are controlled via the touch controls or the bundled remote, and if you fork out an additional two thousand, there's an app-connected LINKD version for smartphone control as well. The other interesting bit is a built-in mood lamp that throws an aesthetic warm yellow light onto the walls, turning into a night lamp when the fan is off.

Now, despite its compact form factor, the Halo does well to redirect airflow precisely where it's needed and comes in handy when you want better air circulation in an already cooled room without the turbulence associated with a powerful ceiling fan. Plus, its quiet operation and around 24W power consumption makes it perfect for all-night bedside use. There are some niggles too, from the lack of height adjustability in the stand to the occasionally fiddly controls. This isn't a replacement for most large ceiling fans, particularly in bigger spaces.

The Brisk air Fryer and the Halo V2 3D fan.

BRĪSK AIR FRYER

A now familiar sight in Indian kitchens, air fryers have now come to look remarkably alike and functionally indistinguishable. Nuuk's Brisk Air Fryer tries to stand out with its 6.5-liter capacity, a transparent cooking basket and a ceramic non-stick coating, all packaged into a finish far more premium than the commonplace black box.

And so, you get a choice of the rather sober gray colour options, but the one to get is definitely the one with the red finish, which lends it a personality that most countertop appliances lack. Whichever Brisk you pick, you get a compact (14.7 x 10.6 x 11 inches) air fryer which should fit easily on most counter tops, although one should note that that the 6.5-litre capacity, while sufficient for everyday cooking, does fall short on speed when it comes to cooking large batches of snacks quickly.

Putting the Brisk through its paces over the festive weeks gone by, the air fryer did well on many occasions, serving up samosas and french fries that belied their air fryer origins in taste, if not in texture. There were occasions, with potato smileys and nuggets, where one had to make adjustments, and even so, the results fell short repeatedly, until they finally didn't.

What really came in handy across most cooks is the transparent basket, which helps avoid interrupting the cooking process each time you pull out the drawer to check progress. Now, you can watch your fries turn golden through the viewing window, and there's even a halfway reminder tells you when it's time to shake or turn your food for an even cook.

Digital controls via a touch panel are easy to use, and presets cover the most familiar cooking jobs (like fries, chicken, fish or veggies). The ceramic coating allows for easy wipes in between cooks, and the tougher residues can be dealt with in the dishwasher. All told, the transparent basket, attractive design and straightforward controls are more than cosmetic flourishes, but don't expect the presets to eliminate all the guesswork from cooking, or the capacity to make batch cooking disappear. The air fryer costs ₹7,499.

STRÖM GO V2 GARMENT STEAMER

Pull out your favourite shirt or top from the luggage during a work trip, only to find it crumpled beyond recognition, and you'll quickly appreciate the case for a compact garment steamer. The Strom Go v2 makes a good first impression, arriving in a travel pouch with a fabric brush to tackle lint. Its 1,000W heating element gets the 120ml water tank ready in around 30 seconds, delivering approximately 20g of steam per minute.

You can tackle creases without an ironing board, whether you're steaming horizontally or vertically, or simply running it over clothes hanging on a hanger. As you'd expect, it works best on lighter fabrics, but for a quick pre-meeting refresh or a last-minute wardrobe rescue, it's a handy travel companion. It costs ₹2,899.

The limitations are fairly predictable, and the compact form which makes it easy to slip into luggage limits its endurance. Heavier fabrics will still need the direct heat of a regular iron, so this is best suited for frequent travellers who want a last-minute solution with minimal fuss, sans pricey hotel ironing fees.

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